RUM & COKE

Written by

CONNOR WRAY



(Printed with the demonstration version of Fade In)

BIG BAND MUSIC. bold white letters against a black screen:

"HOLLYWOOD"

FADE TO:

INT. ARPEGGIO'S ITALIAN RESTAURANT - NIGHT

A warmly lit **fancy** dinner restaurant. Everyone enjoying a meal is wearing an expensive suit, a gorgeous dress, or the odd extravagant outfit.

Two men in their late 30s/early 40s sit together - JAMES CRANE is wearing a brown wool suit and black turtleneck. BOB PAGE, next to him, is wearing a blue pinstripe suit and tie.

They're enjoying pasta and alcohol.

JAMES
Did you ever find out why Diana didn't want to join the project?

BOB
Yes, she-

JAMES
(interrupting)
I mean a $5 million deal and a leading role? Who turns that down on their come-up?

BOB
She does, because there was a better deal, James.

JAMES
Better deal? What better deal, what are you talking about?

BOB
Her agent told me that she was approached by MGM a week before we approached her and asked her to be the love interest to Hackman in some movie they're still working on.

JAMES
How much did they offer her?

BOB
I don't know. Enough, I suppose.

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JAMES
Still, "love interest"? Diana should be a leading lady, am I wrong?

BOB
I don't think so, but at the end of the day it's up to her and her agent. Maybe we can get her for a future project.

James looks away from Bob trying not to act suspicious.

JAMES
Mm-hm.

BOB
What, what's "mm-hm" about? You stumped lately? Hit a bit of a creative wall?

JAMES
(sheepishly)
Not really a wall, kind of just a door that's hard to open. Or like a window that's jammed.

BOB
Tell me what's going on, James. Let me help, I'm a problem solver, that's what I do.

James nods in agreement and shoots down the rest of his martini.

JAMES
We've been working together for ten years now, haven't we?

BOB
Almost eleven, yes. And we've done some excellent work, I think. "Mountain Man".

JAMES
"After Albuquerque."

BOB
"Filibuster."

JAMES
(tearing up)
"Filibuster" was good.

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BOB
"The Modern Barbarian".

JAMES
(crying)
"Michelin Man Goes West".

BOB
James, what the hell is wrong with you? "Michelin Man Goes West" was our worst piece of work, it was a cash grab. What's going on with you?

James wipes his tears and sharpens up.

JAMES
I have a really good idea, Bob. I mean, I love it like...like it's my kid. Like it's my wife. Like it's my first nudey magazine that only I know about.

BOB
Okay, James, that's great. More ideas, more fuel, more work, that's all good news.

JAMES
I want to make it myself.

BOB
What do you mean?

JAMES
I mean I want to...direct it. Write it. Produce it. Everything.

BOB
(confused)
Alright then...so what would I be doing? You want me to be AD? DP? James I don't like messing with cameras.

JAMES
No, no, Bob. I don't want you to do anything. At least not on this project. I want to go after this beast myself, I want to climb this mountain alone. I need to feel like I've got some autonomy, you know?

Bob doesn't know.

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BOB
Yeah, James, I think I know.

JAMES
You do?

BOB
Yeah.

JAMES
(relieved)
Of course you do! You know exactly what I mean, I'm sure it's been a bit draining for you too?

BOB
Oh yeah, of course it has. What has exactly?

JAMES
Me, Bob! I'm trying to talk to everyone, trying to take your scripts - your fucking **tomes** of words, and cut, cut, cut it down to fit into an hour and a half movie.

BOB
Sometimes it can be, yes.

JAMES
Exactly. I don't always love dancing around your lore, suggesting cuts for microscopic details that don't matter, but you'll die on a hill to keep the color of a hat red.

Bob nods, a bit hurt but understanding.

JAMES (cont'd)
I love working with you, Bob, really. I just want to try something different. You get that right?

BOB
Yes, James, I get that. You don't have to coddle me.

JAMES
I know, I've just been stressing about this for months. I don't want you upset with me.

BOB
You've been planning for months?

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JAMES
Well, yeah. I got the idea for this new movie back in July. I've been sitting on it for a while.

BOB
Jesus, James, I wish you would've just told me.

JAMES
I know, I'm sorry. But you know now.

BOB
So, do you want to tell me about this great new movie you're going to make?

JAMES
Yes - but let me use the bathroom first, that martini went right through me.

James gets up and walks away.

For a beat, we're left alone with Bob who looks exhausted.

James comes back.

JAMES (cont'd)
Come with me, I don't want to wait to tell you about it.

INT. ARPEGGIO'S MEN'S ROOM - NIGHT

Bob stands against the wall by the sinks.

James is in one of the stalls with the door closed - we hear him talking and pissing.

JAMES
At it's core, it's a message about the importance of family! Which I think people won't see coming because for most of the movie -

James stops peeing and exits the stall.

JAMES (cont'd)
we're going to be following our heroine tracking these aliens, right?

James washes his hands.

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JAMES (cont'd)
The audience is going to be watching and think "Wow, these guys should never have gotten married in the first place, they're so mean to each other." but by the end they're going to be crying, Bob, crying for them to end up together.
And I've already got someone attached. Helen Royale.

Bob perks up at this.

BOB
You've already got Helen Royale on your movie? How the hell did you do that?

JAMES
Impeccable charisma and ridiculously good luck. Nothing set in stone yet but the cement is poured, just gotta wait for it to dry. It's really all thanks to Catherine, she's been an absolutely amazing producer.

BOB
Catherine knew you were planning on going solo?

JAMES
Yeah! I'm honestly surprised she didn't tell you, I thought she'd crack.

BOB
Yeah, me too.

EXT. ARPEGGIO'S ITALIAN RESTAURANT - NIGHT

Bob and James both stand outside the restaurant. James is waiting for his car.

James stands tall and relieved - the talk couldn't have gone better.

Bob is staring off with a solemn expression, like he's just been told his mom died.

JAMES
I really appreciate you, Bob. You've helped me feel better about this whole thing.

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BOB
Anytime, James.

JAMES
And I appreciate you for everything you've done for me these past ten years. I wouldn't be here without you.

Despite his upset, Bob is genuinely touched by this.

BOB
I wouldn't be here without you too.

James' car pulls up in front of him. He tips the valet.

JAMES
Do you want me to drive you back home?

BOB
No, I'll get a cab. I don't want to put you out of your way.

JAMES
No worries. Get home safe, Bob. I'll be talking to you soon.

Bob waves goodbye as James gets in his luxurious black car and drives off.

Bob doesn't hail a cab. He just stands on the side of the street processing everything that happened over dinner.

He's lost his job security, comfort, and routine. Bob is lost.

INT. BOB'S HOME - NIGHT

It's the same night. Bob has arrived at his immaculate home, lined with academic classic texts. His suit is still on with the exception of a slightly loosened tie.

He pours himself a glass of whiskey on the rocks - by which is a framed photo of Bob and James celebrating.

"*CREATIVE DUO SHAKE UP HOLLYWOOD WITH DEBUT FILM: '**SOUTH OF MANCHESTER**'" - 10/09/69*

Bob smiles bitterly and holds his glass up in a toast to him and his friends long run as a duo, then drinks.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

BIG BAND MUSIC KICKS IN AS WE CUT TO:

INT. REDBONE PRODUCTION STUDIOS - DAY

James struts through the office in a brown suit - he feels amazing. Many people greet him and he greets them back.

James approaches a door with a golden plaque:

CATHERINE MONROE: EXECUTIVE PRODUCER

James knocks - then enters without waiting for an answer.

CATHERINE is an older woman wearing a black pantsuit who is on the phone.

CATHERINE
(speaking on the phone)
- I told Harry "No, I'm not going to give you five more fucking million dollars to make a movie about a horse!".

JAMES
Catherine!

CATHERINE
Jimmy! Not now, on the phone, important work.

James knows it isn't important work.

JAMES
Uh-huh, no problem. Just wanted to let you know I had that talk with Bob.

CATHERINE
(moves the phone away from her mouth)
Yeah? How did that go?

JAMES
It went great! We're good to go for "Star Pilgrim!"

CATHERINE
Love, love, love! Thank you, James! Writers room with you tomorrow, 8am. Be there with your treatment.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JAMES
I'll be there.

CATHERINE
You're a gem. Get outta here, James.

JAMES
Tell your mom I said "Hi!".

James shuts the door as he exits.

CLOSEUP ON CATHERINE'S GOLDEN PLAQUE.

CUT TO:

CLOSEUP ON SIMILAR GOLDEN PLAQUE:

MARTY HEINZ: EXECUTIVE PRODUCER

INT. MARTY'S OFFICE - DAY

Bob is sitting on a couch in Marty's office - his head in his hands.

Marty is sitting behind a large desk, a man with slicked back hair and coke-bottle glasses.

Beat.

MARTY
I don't get it.

BOB
(head in hands)
What don't you get, Marty?

MARTY
Why you're all weepy.

Bob straightens himself.

BOB
I'm not a duo anymore Marty, I'm just me. You know how it is for writers' out here, it's shit. No one wants to hire a writer with scripts over 200 pages long.

MARTY
No, they don't Bob. But you're not a loser virgin. So what if your boyfriend broke up with you?
(MORE)

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

MARTY (cont'd)
You gonna come to my office and whine about it for one of my precious hours?

BOB
I'm turning to a friend. What would you do?

MARTY
I wouldn't be a writer. But you also need to remember you're not a virgin in this industry either, Bobby. You've got some mileage on you, some experience. A lot of projects under your belt. If you can write a script that is NOT 200 pages then I might be able to sell it to some desperate shmuck director who wants to make it.

BOB
And who would produce it? You?

MARTY
Probably not me, Bobby. But I know people who might be interested - if it's good enough.

Bob sits back and stares at the ceiling.

MARTY (cont'd)
What are you doing? What is this, now?

BOB
I'm thinking...I'm lost, Marty. It's strange to work on something without James. I don't know what to write about.

MARTY
You like stuff, don't you Bob?

Marty pulls out a cigarette.

BOB
Yes?

MARTY
Like what?

Marty lights and starts smoking his cigarette.

BOB
Classic literature. Poetry, history, theater, opera. I love the fine arts, epic tales, things the modern movie goer doesn't have the attention span for.

MARTY
Brilliant, find a way to make the modern movie goer love that stuff as much as you do.

Bob has gears in his head turning.

BOB
How should I do that?

MARTY
Jesus Christ Bobby, am I your therapist and your assistant? You want me to braid your hair and get you coffee? You're a writer for God's sake - writing will make you feel better! Get out of my office and come back when you have a script!

BOB
Alright!

Bob gets up and leaves the office.

INT. BOB'S HOME - DAY

Bob sits in front of a type writer with only one thing written:

EXT.

He stares in contemplation.

It's not working. He gets up and scans his home library. He goes over binders of his old scripts and then sees classic books:

"Count of Monte Cristo", *"Ben-Hur*", "*Julius Caesar*" etc.

He pulls out Shakespeare's "*Julius Caesar*". and starts reading.

He ends up making it a long way through until he comes across the line:

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"Not that I loved Caesar less, but that I loved Rome more..."

Something clicks and he moves to the typewriter and continues writing:

EXT. ROME

INT. WRITERS' ROOM - DAY

A team of writers sits in the office having quiet timid conversation with each other.

James bursts into the room with a manila folder in hand - he is wearing another new suit.

JAMES
Good morning, good morning, everyone! How are we doing today?

The writers respond with vacant stares and silence.

JAMES (cont'd)
Brilliant!

James pulls copies of the treatment out of his manila folder and passes them around to the writers.

JAMES (cont'd)
I present to you all a treatment for "Star Pilgrim". We've got 15 pages of material to work with to get an understanding of what we're going for. I want a family movie, something grounded - but with an undeniable in your face element of "space whimsy". Any questions?

No response from the writers, they start reading the treatment.

James shifts awkwardly in his seat as the writers read quietly. James sees waving through a window of the room - it's Catherine.

Once she gets James' attention she smiles and gives him a thumbs up.

James gives a far less certain thumbs up back. Catherine moves on.

The writers wrap up reading the treatment.

JAMES (cont'd)
How do we feel?

Writers quietly look around at each other waiting for someone to say something.

JAMES (cont'd)
(frustrated)
Come on, I need something. Is it good? Is it bad? Do you guys know what we're going for? QUESTIONS! COMMENTS! CONCERNS! Give them to me!

One writer sheepishly raises his hand.

JAMES (cont'd)
Yes, you! What's your name?

KENNY
Kenny McFarlane.

JAMES
Kenny, amazing. What do you got for me?

KENNY
Who is the main character?

James bites his lip and puts his head down. He lets out a big sigh before tilting his head back up - more calm.

JAMES
Her name is "Martha"...

INT. JAMES' HOME - NIGHT

James has a landline phone to his ear - it's ringing. Bob answers.

BOB
Hello? Page speaking.

JAMES
Bob! Hey, it's James! How's it going?

BOB
Oh, James! Good to hear from you. Everything's going pretty good so far, it's been a busy couple of days.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JAMES
Busy couple of days, huh? I'd love to hear all about it, I've had a pretty wild week myself so far. You want to meet up for coffee and breakfast to talk about everything?

BOB
I'd love to, but if everything goes well this week I'll be pretty booked up. Actually, I think I need to let you go, James, I really need to focus. But I'll call you back, yeah? We'll find time to meet up, I promise.

JAMES
Oh, of course. No worries, Bob. Good luck with your work. Talk to you soon.

BOB
Thanks, James.

INT. BOB'S HOME - NIGHT

Bob hangs up the phone. We see him standing before a unit of cork boards, string, pins, and note-cards.

He has created a conspiracy board of lore and plot details for his story.

MONTAGE

Bob writes pages upon pages of script. We see little excerpts of text and setting:

"Acropolis" / "EXT. Colosseum" / "The oracle said that Rome will fall..." etc.

The pages stack higher and higher until the title page rests on top:

The Centurion.

INT. MARTY'S OFFICE - DAY

Marty is smoking a cigarette and reading a script that he scoffs at. It's not very good.

Bob enters the room looking exhausted and holding his script.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

BOB
Morning, Marty.

MARTY
Good God, Bob, you look like hell. What have you been doing?

Bob slams the script down on Marty's desk and gets close to his face - a wild look in his eyes.

BOB
Writing.

Mary inspects the script.

MARTY
"*The Centurion*"? What, like the Japanese bikes? They're good.

BOB
Centurion like ancient Roman military soldier.

MARTY
Interesting...what's this Centurion do exactly?

BOB
The doom of Rome is foretold by an enemy forces Oracle, his government betrays him, he sees the cracks in the empire...he's forced to decide if he wants to keep the cushy life of a military hero or if he needs to help bring about the end of the Roman empire for the greater good.

MARTY
Very bold, Bobby. Very "epic". Sounds like something modern movie goers wouldn't have the stomach for it, though.

BOB
They might have the stomach for 130 pages, Marty.

MARTY
130 pages?

Marty checks the script. 130 pages indeed.

MARTY (cont'd)
I'll be damned Bobby, you did it. Where did you get the motive?

Bob collapses back on the couch.

BOB
I always had it, Marty.

MARTY
You have any condensed versions I can show to potential directors? Any log-lines?

BOB
Between the cover page and page 1 of the script.

Marty checks - everything is there. He's impressed.

MARTY
I'll call some people, Bobby. Good work.

INT. WRITERS' ROOM - DAY

James is in the writers' room looking intently at a board before him.

A play-by-play note-card list of scenes is laid-out on a board. They have character and setting descriptions as well as prop and set design needs.

KENNY
Strong female lead character, which you have as Helen Royale - I think she's great. Martha is a military woman, she works hard but is still kind. We see that balance come out when "Eckert" comes to earth and she has to take care of it. We want her to be the character audiences can admire and strive to be as badass as, while still wanting someone like her as their girlfriend or maybe their mom.

James doesn't know how to feel about what he's hearing.

JAMES
I getcha. What are we thinking for "Eckert"? Eckert is the alien, right?

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KENNY
Eckert is the alien. We want something odd-looking but still lovable. Something like Scrappy-Doo, or a plaid-recliner. Oh, and Catherine said she wanted it to be "marketable". We're thinking something along the lines of a really big moth baby. We have concept artists working on it now.

JAMES
I see. I...like it.

KENNY
You like it?

JAMES
(convincing himself)
Yeah, I like it. Keep it coming, tell me more.

GWEN enters the writers' room and knocks on the door after she is already standing in the room.

GWEN
James?

JAMES
Hi Gwen, what can we do for you?

GWEN
You've got a call waiting with the secretary.

JAMES
I'll be right there.

James turns to the writers.

JAMES (cont'd)
We'll continue in a moment, I'll keep this call quick.

CUTTING BACK AND FORTH BETWEEN SECRETARY DESK AND BOB'S HOME.

Bob and James speak over the phone - Gwen is standing by James as he talks.

JAMES (cont'd)
Hello?

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

BOB
James! Did I catch you at a bad time?

JAMES
Oh, Bob! No, no, not at all. Just stepping away from a writers room meeting but it's probably for the best, I'm having a hard time seeing the vision. What's on your mind?

BOB
I have a script circulating out there.

JAMES
Out where?

BOB
Out among the directors, James. Marty is sending my latest work out to directors he thinks might be interested in it.

James is shocked/confused. He didn't expect this to happen.

JAMES
R-really? That's incredible Bob, I didn't realize you were even working on a script.

BOB
I didn't until a couple of months ago. Marty gave me a little push and told me to start writing so I did! 130 pages.

JAMES
130 pages, that's incredible Bob. You really found a good groove it sounds like.

BOB
I do, James. I really do. I've got a good feeling about this. I keep reading the script, I love it. It might be my best work yet, I really think it might be.

James can't fake being happy physically, but he tries to keep a happy voice.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JAMES
Best work yet is high praise for you, Bob, I'm excited to see what it's all about.

BOB
You'll have to wait until it's in theaters like everyone else, my friend.

JAMES
I can't wait. Hey, Bob, I should be getting back to this writers' meeting here.

BOB
Of course, of course! I just wanted to let you know.

JAMES
And I'm glad you did.

BOB
Let me know if you have any time soon to grab any dinner and catch up, will you?

JAMES
You know I will. Bye-bye, Bob.

James hangs up.

INT. SECRETARY DESK - DAY

James sets the phone down and rests his head on the desk.

The SECRETARY moves her notepad out of the way and continues writing notes.

Gwen watches James sulk and scratches his back lovingly.

JAMES
You want to go out for drinks tonight?

GWEN
Very much.

INT. TURK'S HEAD PUB - NIGHT

James and Gwen are out drinking. They both sip on fancy margaritas and have a couple of already empty glasses.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JAMES
I didn't even know he was working on a script, and now it's "out there"? What the fuck is that?!

GWEN
It's tough, James. But didn't you do something similar to him before you got "Star Pilgrim" off the ground?

JAMES
No, I did the nice thing and took him out to dinner and kindly told him that I had been planning for months to cut off the duo so I could work on this myself.
Also the writers want to call it "Satellite". I don't know how I feel about that.

GWEN
I like it. One word titles are iconic: "*Chinatown*", "*Patton*", "*Jaws*", "*Satellite*". It works.

JAMES
I guess so.

GWEN
Why are you so iffy about these writers?

JAMES
I don't know, I think we're just adjusting to each other. I'm used to Bob being my main writer, I knew what to expect, it was easy to communicate. Life was simple. This is a big shift, no one talks and when they do I don't know what they're going to say.

GWEN
That's what happens when you want to take a big risk, James; you get big challenges. You can do this, it's just going to be awkward, uncomfortable, and probably very difficult. Especially now that Bob is your competition.

JAMES
What do you mean "competition"?

GWEN
James, when you started telling me about "Star Pilgrim", "Satellite", whatever - you were so passionate. And you kept rounding it back to: "I'm going to win so many awards". You still want to win, right?

JAMES
So badly.

GWEN
Right. Well, don't you think Bob wants that too?

JAMES
(unsure)
No? He's a humble guy, he never talked about ambitions to win any awards, not that I remember anyway.

GWEN
Hmm...well, whether he wants to or not, he has a chance to. And the way it sounded like he was talking over the phone, there's a good chance he'll be up for "best screenplay" next award season.

JAMES
That's fine, I'm not even going after "best screenplay".

GWEN
A best screenplay can lead to a best movie.

JAMES
Yeah, but a great director can turn a crummy script into a best movie too.

GWEN
Anything can happen, I'm just saying you guys are out of the duo now. That means if either of you are trying to get an award - that automatically makes the other competition. And I bet as soon as the press finds out, they're going to turn it into a social bet on which one of you will win.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JAMES
Don't put that evil on me Gwen, the press will make anything up.

GWEN
They might not have to make it up. I'm telling you: Competition.

JAMES
Friendly competition.

Gwen raises her eyebrows in a "if you say so" expression. They both take a sip of their drinks.

INT. BOB'S HOME - DAY

Bob is sitting at home sipping tea and watching "*Cleopatra*" (1963).

His leg is bouncing anxiously.

He looks over to his right - his landline sits on a nearby coffee table not ringing.

Bob returns his attention to the movie.

RING! RING! R- Bob jumps out of his seat to the phone.

BOB
(calmly)
This is Bob Page.

MARTY
(over the phone)
Good morning, Bobby. Sorry I went M.I.A. on you. I didn't have you nervously waiting by the phone did I?

Beat.

BOB
No, of course not.

MARTY
Of course. Well, Bobby, I have some good news for you. I made some calls, pulled some strings, had some meetings...I've got some directors who are interested in your script.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

BOB
(perking up)
Really? That's fantastic, Marty, thank you! How about producers, any lead on that?

MARTY
You're talking to him, Bobby.

BOB
Marty, you said it wouldn't be you.

MARTY
I said it "probably" wouldn't be me. But I'll tell you, Bob, I like the script. I like it a lot. And I like how these directors are talking.

BOB
They're talking about it?

MARTY
They're excited about it. And so am I. Make sure your schedule is open these coming 2 weeks, you're going to have a lot of meetings.

BOB
Of course. Really, Marty, I can't thank you enough.

MARTY
Really, I'm happy to do it. Hey, Bobby? You know what I smell? ***Money.***

MONTAGE:

EXT. POOLSIDE - DAY

Bob sits across from a man wearing a navy blue sweater, a white ascot, and gold rimmed sunglasses.

BOB
I see you've had a decent bit of experience, Randy. Got your start in '65 and have been putting out projects about once a year.

RANDY (DIRECTOR 1)
Yes sir: "*Halibut*", "*Man of War*", "*Dire Circumstances*, and "*Last Week in Bermuda*". My babies.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

BOB
Impressive consistency, but it also seems like all of these have... failed? Why do you think that is?

Randy shrugs.

RANDY (DIRECTOR 1)
Not enough money.

Beat. Bob takes notes.

BOB
Right.

CUT TO:

INT. CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

Bob sits across from an older man wearing large square glasses, a tweed jacket, and a very noticeable toupee.

BOB
It looks like just about all of your previous works are related to history. Lots of documentaries and historical fiction.

SETH (DIRECTOR 2)
That's right, you could say history is my passion.

BOB
(excited)
I feel the same way. What about history do you love?

SETH (DIRECTOR 2)
Well, the culture is just beautiful. You read all these books about Greece and Egypt and you realize how comfortable everyone was with each other in the nude. I miss that. I want to show more of that, you know?

BOB
(disappointed)
I see where you're coming from.

CUT TO:

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

INT. GARRET'S OFFICE - DAY

Bob sits on the opposite side of a desk from a man with a thick artificial tan, sunglasses, and a scally cap.

GARRET (DIRECTOR 3)
What do you know about making movies?

BOB
(insulted)
I've worked as a professional screenwriter in this industry for a decade.

GARRET (DIRECTOR 3)
Yeah, but what do you know about "movies"!?

BOB
I know I'd like to get mine made - now your history is pretty impressive, you've worked on-

GARRET (DIRECTOR 3)
You're dodging the question.

CUT TO:

EXT. CAFE - DAY

Bob sits across from a man wearing a deep-v shirt, bellbottom pants, and lots of bead necklaces.

BOB
I've actually seen some of your movies; your style is so unique. It'd be a risk using it for historical fiction but I think it might work.

NORM (DIRECTOR 4)
I've seen some of your movies too, Bob. They're not bad, but they all have a similar problem.

BOB
(hesitant)
I'm glad you've got some ideas, but let's stay on topic.

NORM (DIRECTOR 4)
They're predictable, Bob. I actually took your script and annotated it, I thought we could go through it.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

Norm sets a HEAVILY annotated script on the table between them.

Bob lets out a deep sigh of exasperation.

BOB
Oh, that's so nice...

CUT TO:

INT. CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

Bob's head is in his hands as he listens to Seth.

SETH (DIRECTOR 2)
There's something *empowering* about having your boobs out - that's what I tell my actresses. And I'm also thinking we could show a couple men's action off if you catch my drift.

BOB
(harshly)
Yep.

CUT TO:

EXT. POOLSIDE - DAY

Bob is scribbling in his notes as Randy rambles.

RANDY (DIRECTOR 1)
People give me shit because my dad is my producer - that has *nothing* to do with my success! I'm self made! Did you know I *invented "James Bond"*?

Bob nods along - we see over his shoulder that he is playing Hangman in the notepad - the answer solved:

"K I L L M E"

CUT TO:

EXT. CAFE - DAY

Norm is several pages deep into his breakdown of Bob's script.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WAY

NORM (DIRECTOR 4)
Why the hell does Titus need to have a wife? Everybody has a wife, that's not cool. We *expect* the wife, Bob. See this is what I mean? Every minute detail is so predictable.

BOB
(snaps)
Norm - shut the hell up! I'm interviewing *you!* And you're failing hard! I don't need your subjective and trite fucking notes right now, you're not even on the project!

A barista comes by with a coffee pot.

BARISTA
(cheerily)
Anybody need a refill?

BOB / NORM
(simultaneously)
Not now!

CUT TO:

INT. GARRET'S OFFICE - DAY

Bob and Garret are still in their loop. They're yelling at each other now.

GARRET (DIRECTOR 3)
What the hell are you talking about, do you even know what 3-point-lighting is, you idiot?

BOB
Yes! I know what 3-point-lighting is, but I don't need to! That's YOUR job! I write the damned scripts!

GARRET (DIRECTOR 3)
I don't care about your words, fella, it's about what you see that matters!

BOB
(hitting his script)
There's nothing to fucking look at on screens if you don't have the base of a SCRIPT first!

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

GARRET (DIRECTOR 3)
You ever heard of "viewpoints", fancy boy?

Bob grabs his script and rushes out of the office.

CUT TO:

INT. A TASTE OF SICILY - DAY

Bob sits across from MARNA ORVILLE. She is wearing a black turtleneck, sunglasses, a beret, and looks very serious.

Bob taps his pencil in his notebook, wondering what to ask first.

Bob sets his pencil down and asks the first question that comes to mind.

BOB
Are you a crazy person?

MARNA
Yes. It's Los Angeles, there isn't a single person here who can honestly say they're sound of mind.

Bob sighs in disappointment.

BOB
Yeah, I suppose you're right. You don't have much of a resume, only 3 films over 9 years.

MARNA
And 1 television series of 1 season.

BOB
Why so little work?

MARNA
I'm selective and attentive. If there is a script I like, that I can envision clearly, and makes me feel something strong, I will dedicate my life to making it *perfect*. I could see your script on screen so clearly, Robert. I can bring it to life if you'll let me.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

BOB
(pleasantly surprised)
I'm glad to hear that Ms. Orville. What exactly do you envision for this project?

MARNA
Good question...let's take the Oracle scene, when Titus it told the fate of the Roman empire.

Marna leans forward.

MARNA (cont'd)
(intensely)
Darkness within the Oracle's cave. Lit only by the orange flickering torchlight. We stay perfectly straight with our view of Titus -

Marna puts her hands on either side of Bob's head to block out his periphery - helping him visualize.

MARNA (cont'd)
and the Oracle - played by the same actress as his wife. Aged up significantly, of course. There she waits, quietly, ancient and tired. Is she dead? Did he come here for nothing? No - she wheezes back to life, and Titus, our powerful protagonist, is unsettled by this. Everyone fears that which they do not understand. He presses forward, fully entering the Oracle's cave. He greets her:
(in a mans voice)
"Great and wise Oracle of Alexandria...I am Titus, a Cent-"
(in an old raspy voice)
"A centurion of Rome...I know, young Titus. Unburden yourself to me..."
(in normal voice)
They speak for a while, made tense and uncanny by the lighting...the long pauses between dialogue...the unnatural look of the Oracle...the music...until finally, the Oracle tells Titus the grim news.
(in an old raspy voice)
"Rome...will fall."
(MORE)

MARNA (cont'd)
(in normal voice)
Heavy drums kick in - Titus is mortified. He fears everything the Oracle has said will come to pass and so we CUT - Titus is riding away from the cave on his mighty horse - lightning flashes across the night sky as though Jupiter himself was assuring the end to be nye...and we hear the Oracle cackling horribly from the cave, echoing through Titus' ears and the audiences all the way back home...

Beat.

Marna sits back and waits for a response.

Bob stares at her, open mouthed in amazement.

INT. ARPEGGIO'S ITALIAN RESTAURANT - NIGHT

Three glasses of champagne clink together. Bob, Marty, and Marna. They are sitting together in a booth with a nice bottle of champagne on ice before them.

MARTY
Congratulations to you both, I was hoping it'd be you Marna.

MARNA
Of course you did, I'm the best.

BOB
Marna, truly, you are *the* best person to bring this picture to life. I'm very excited to work with you.

MARNA
You're both very kind - and I'm thrilled to be attached to this project. I have lots of ideas already that I'd love to share with you.

BOB
Yes! I'm thinking we could *actually* film in Italy -

Marty chokes on his drink and sits forward.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

MARTY
Let's slow down there, shall we? We just landed us a stellar director, let's celebrate that, yeah? Let's celebrate Marna. You've got your base production budget but if you want to go to Italy we'll have a talk about that. But later.

BOB
No problem, Marty.

MARNA
Of course. But before we cut off all shop talk, I do have one important note we need to prepare for.

MARTY
What's that, Marn?

MARNA
Davina. The wife of Titus *and* Oracle. She's a very important role that makes Titus and the audience think... She needs to be iconic.

Marty is nodding along, invested. Bob is looking at Marna, not quite sure where she's going with this.

MARNA (cont'd)
I need Helen Royale.

Bob's excitement sinks into uncertainty and worry.

Marty smiles.

MARTY
Yes! Helen Royale, why didn't I think of that? I love that!

Marna notices Bob's silence.

MARNA
Robert? You disagree?

BOB
No! No, I think Helen Royale is a fantastic idea. I'm just not sure how we'd get her.

MARTY
(obviously)
I'd give her a call and throw some money her way.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

BOB
I more mean - what if she's attached to another project?

MARTY
I know some good lawyers, some sleazy lawyers, whatever the occasion calls for - they'll be able to find some kind of clause or loophole in her contract, if she's signed one, to get her on our side.

BOB
You think she'll go for that?

MARTY/MARNA
(simultaneously)
Yes.

CLOSE ON BOB

A guilty expression is plastered on Bob's face but he tries to hide it.

BOB
(uncertainly)
Amazing.

Bob finishes his drink.

INT. ART DEPARTMENT - DAY

James and Kenny are sitting in adjacent chairs at a free-standing table - scripts and notebooks in front of them.

They are staring ahead - studying whatever is before them very carefully.

THE CAMERA TURNS AND WE SEE WHAT THEY'RE LOOKING AT:

Alien concept art. There is little to no consistency - one is a horrifying monstrosity, another looks like it belongs in a Disney film, another looks humanoid and over exposed.

Kenny leans over to James slowly.

KENNY
(whispers)
What do you think?

JAMES
(whispers)
I'm not sure what I'm looking at.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

SUSAN
(enthusiastically)
Aliens! You're looking at aliens, James. We've got killer: hunter, predator, hungry for blood. Friendly: your buddy, your pal, marketable to kids. The humanoid: familiar, lovable, attractive. Animated, animalistic, shapeshifting, small, big, fuckin' flying. James, my art department has spent the past 3 weeks putting together a long list of potential aliens for you - their race, name, background, everything.

JAMES
(surprised)
Wow, Susan, you really went all out for this.

SUSAN
I love aliens, James.

JAMES
I guess so.

James gets up and inspects the wall of concept art.

CLOSE PAN ACROSS ALIEN SPECIES' UNTIL JAMES' FINGER LANDS ON ONE:

The alien James is pointing to looks like a short cicada standing bipedally.

JAMES (cont'd)
Tell me about this one.

SUSAN
In the script we have a scene where Martha is trying to outrun some government scientists with "Jubo" - the alien. Jubo "emits a shrill noise that makes the scientists drop to their knees and cover their ears", allowing Martha and Jubo to escape. That's where we get this cicada look, high pitched noises will be natural - endearing and weird. It's cute, it's unnatural, it's versatile, it's marketable. He comes from the planet "Kobona" and lives a long long life. He's about 70 years old and still in his infancy.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JAMES
(nodding)
That all works with the script. I like it a lot.

KENNY
(raising his hand)
I-I like it too.

SUSAN
Great! Which one do you want to hear about next?

JAMES
None of them, I like the Kobona Jubo. We'll go with the bug kid.

James plucks the art of the cicada alien off the wall and hands it to Kenny to examine.

Susan looks disappointed that she won't get to show off any more aliens.

JAMES (cont'd)
We've got storyboard and shot-list ready too, don't we?

SUSAN
We do, yeah. Want us to wheel that in?

JAMES
Please.

SUSAN
(calling to the door)
SHOT LIST!

Two men on either side of a white board come in with many pictures of drawn frames laid out - **the storyboard.**

Then another white board is wheeled in with more pictures.

Then a third.

JAMES
We got it all here, wow.

Then a fourth.

Then a fifth.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JAMES (cont'd)
(overwhelmed)
Oh, shit, ok.

Finally a sixth.

The room is almost full now.

SUSAN
Fellas, can we try to arrange this in a way that we can work around? Try and make a circle, put us in the middle.

The 12 men arrange the 6 whiteboards with storyboarding in a loose circle around Susan, Kenny, and James.

They're closed in. All 3 of them look around, trying to figure out how to begin.

JAMES
Where do we start?

INT. HALLWAY - DAY

Heels on feet rushing down a hall past doors - she's getting to something important.

The heels approach a door at the end of the hallway and we LIFT CAMERA UP TO SEE THE FACE OF GWEN. She looks worried and angry.

She throws the door open and we follow her eyeline to see: A circle of 6 whiteboards encasing James, Kenny and Susan. All of their heads peak up or around the whiteboards to look at her.

Beat.

GWEN
We might lose Helen Royale.

INT. CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

CHAOS.

James is standing up with a worried look on his face.

Kenny is pacing.

Catherine is sitting at the head of the conference table reading their contract with HELEN ROYALE.

Susan is sitting to the audience's right of Catherine.

Gwen is standing on the opposite end of the table from James.

There is a landline in the middle of the table.

CATHERINE
I'm telling you, James, this doesn't fucking happen. Not with people like Helen Royale - it happens with stuck-up Nepo babies and Broadway trash, not real talent.

JAMES
Gwen said she got a call from Helen's agent, Tom -

GWEN
Tom said there was another offer Helen was considering, a project that wants *her specifically*.

JAMES
WE want her specifically! What the hell is this other project?

GWEN
He wouldn't say - only that it's a really good offer. Apparently the meeting is happening today, Tom said he'd call back when Helen made up his mind.

CATHERINE
When did he say this?

GWEN
He called 30 minutes ago.

KENNY
What time is the meeting Helen is having?

GWEN
He wouldn't say.

SUSAN
How long do we have to wait?

GWEN
I don't know.

The whole room collectively groans in frustration.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

GWEN (cont'd)
(defensively)
I don't have all of the answers for things like this! It's 15 til noon, we could be waiting all day to hear back.

CATHERINE
Nuh-uh, fuck that. I'm not waiting for this shit to happen.

Catherine picks up the phone and calls TOM.

There's several rings and the room is dead silent.

No answer - Catherine THROWS the phone back at the base.

CATHERINE (cont'd)
FUCKER!

JAMES
Tom isn't going to pick up, he knows we'll be calling with questions he either can't or won't answer. Call someone on our side, call our lawyer, call Tony.

Catherine dials TONY's number and puts the landline on speaker for the room.

Again, the room is silent as the phone rings - there is an answer.

TONY
(over the phone)
Tony Usher.

CATHERINE
It's Catherine. Tony, we're in a real shit-storm right now.

TONY
What's happening?

CATHERINE
That "Satellite" movie we're working on - our lead, Helen Royale, is having a *meeting* to potentially drop out of our movie. We have a contract with her to commit her to our project. You remember typing that up?

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

TONY
Uhh...yeah, I think I do. We did that a couple of months ago. That contract should be pretty airtight.

CATHERINE
Thank you! So, what do we do? Can we sue her, can we tell this other project to fuck off? What are our options, Tony?

TONY
Yeah, you can do either of those as long as she's not violating the Pre-Production contingency.

Beat.

James leans in.

JAMES
I'm...I'm sorry, James Crane here, Tony. The Pre-Production contingency?

TONY
Yeah, let me pull up the contract on my end here...yes, yes, it's on page 13. "This contract in any court of law serves as physical proof that Ms. Helen C. Royale commits herself to Redbone Production Studios for a maximum of 91 days beginning in August of 1979 concluding at the end of October 1979 (or beginning of November 1979)."

The room nods along.

TONY (cont'd)
"This commitment may be subject to acceptable violation on the pretense that: Redbone Production Studios have chosen to change talent - the subject of this contract is affected by terminal struggle, dire familial turmoil, or acts of God - or if the pre-production phase has not entered effect within a month of this documents signing and notarizing."

The morale in the room evaporates immediately.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

CATHERINE
Thank you, Tony.

TONY
No problem. Good luck.

Catherine ends the call - *click*.

James hangs his head low.

JAMES
I took too long to talk to Bob about this...I couldn't get us off the ground fast enough. Fuck, we might lose our lead.

GWEN
It's ok, James. We still have a chance.

The room is silent.

INT. MARTY'S OFFICE - DAY

Bob, Marna, and Marvin all sit by Marvin's desk waiting patiently.

The clock ticks by.

Tick. Tick. Tick. Tick.

Clack. Clack. Clack. Clack.

EXT. MARTY'S OFFICE - DAY

Tall expensive heels clack down the hall to Marty's office.

People in offices / at desks nearby look up from their work and pause talking on calls to look.

BEHIND: We see thick curly dark hair, a red hat and red dress with a black purse.

INT. MARTY'S OFFICE - DAY

Knock! Knock! Knock!

Bob gets up and opens the door, revealing:

Helen Royale.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

(Printed with the demonstration version of Fade In)

She is wearing large sunglasses and is sporting a perpetual "model" face with no notable emotion. She is stunning and captivates the room.

HELEN ROYALE
Let's make this quick.

Bob steps aside to let her in.

Helen enters.

MARTY
Helen Royale! I was worried we wouldn't get the chance to meet.

HELEN ROYALE
Mr. Heinz, it's a pleasure. I got your message from your lawyers - "The role I was born to play.", "The role I will be remembered for.", "The role I've been dreaming of."

MARTY
All accurate descriptions, I'd say.

Helen sits across the desk.

HELEN ROYALE
I wouldn't.

Marty and Bob look worried.

HELEN ROYALE (cont'd)
The role I was born to play was Lisa Carol Fremont. The role I will be remembered for will be all of them because I put all of myself into all of my characters. And I don't dream of roles, Mr. Heinz, I don't dream at all. The medicine and herbal smoothies and night disrupt my REM sleep enough so that I never dream. I close my eyes, experience a restful 8 hours of sleep in what feels to me like 5 minutes, and I get to work again.

MARTY
(nodding)
I see.

Bob sits at the desk again.

(Printed with the demonstration version of Fade In)

BOB
Ms. Royale - have you seen the script yet?

HELEN ROYALE
I have. I've read it, and I'll admit, it's compelling. That's why I've agreed to meet with you. I think it has potential. But right now I'm looking at a talented writer, a silver-tongued producer, and a director I've never heard of.

MARNA
(introducing self)
Marna Orville.

HELEN ROYALE
(introducing self)
Helen Royale.

BOB
We'd want you for Davina. She's a very prominent character. She's powerful, compelling, influential.

HELEN ROYALE
I know. You should also know that I am currently attached to another project that would like to have me for the *lead* role. Why should I take Davina - a good character, but secondary role - over my first offer.

MARNA
We also want you to be the Oracle. Not only do you carry the flow of the story throughout the film as Davina, you set everything up as the Oracle. Two polarly opposite characters, hardly anything in common.

HELEN ROYALE
You want me to play 2 roles? Neither of them leading?

MARNA
You like a good challenge, don't you? Think about it, Davina: the loving political figure, maternal in her own way. Powerful, independent but kind. She kills 3 kidnappers that enter her home by herself.
(MORE)

MARNA (cont'd)
Then, the Oracle: Ancient, wise, mysterious. Open to interpretation for the actor and the audience. Almost divine in her own way. Two powerful roles in opposition to one another. You get to show off your range. You may not be the lead, but you *will* steal the show. You may not be remembered for these roles, but people will not forget them.

Beat.

Bob and Marty are impressed.

Helen Royale nods, also impressed.

HELEN ROYALE
I like you. All of you. How long do I have to give you an answer?

BOB
Does a week sound fair?

HELEN ROYALE
It does. You'll hear from me. Soon.

She stands up and walks to the door. She stops a few feet from it.

HELEN ROYALE (cont'd)
The door.

Bob, Marty and Marna look at each other confused.

HELEN ROYALE (cont'd)
(more insistent)
The door.

Bob, Marty, and Marna whisper to each other about what to do.

HELEN ROYALE (cont'd)
(looking back at them)
The *door*.

It clicks.

Bob runs up and opens the door for Helen Royale.

Helen Royale pats Bob kindly on the cheek and walks out.

Bob shuts the door and turns to the others.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

All 3 of them burst out in cheers as they realize they've almost certainly booked Helen Royale for their picture.

INT. CONFERENCE ROOM - NIGHT

The sun is setting outside Redbone Production Studios.

James, Catherine, Gwen, Susan, and Kenny are now all sitting around the table. Everyone looks miserable.

The landline is on speaker.

TOM
Helen is dropping out of "Satellite".

Nobody says a word.

INT. ART DEPARTMENT - NIGHT

FOCUS ON A BOARD COVERED IN DETAILS FOR HELEN ROYALE'S CHARACTER IN SATELLITE: MARTHA

James begins stripping the board of the drawings and lists - ripping each page off with more and more anger each time.

INT. WRITERS' ROOM - NIGHT

JAMES SITS ALONE IN THE ROOM - A SINGLE WARM LIGHT ILLUMINATES HIM.

He switches back and forth between typing on a type-writer details for a casting call for Martha and writing out details on a piece of paper about what they could change about alternate solutions.

Gwen walks in and stands in the doorway. She watches in silence for a moment - James doesn't seem to notice.

GWEN
(quietly)
You doing ok?

JAMES
(choking up)
Yeah. Yeah, I'm doing alright, Gwen, just...trying to make up for the work we just lost.

GWEN
I know.

Gwen walks to him and rubs his shoulder affectionately.

GWEN (cont'd)
It's a shitty thing.

JAMES
(angrily)
Yeah, it's really shitty. We've been working on this for months and she hasn't had any issue with the fact that we got started on pre-production late until we ACTUALLY got started on pre-production and now she drops out and finds a different project! Who the fuck does that?

Gwen nods, letting him vent.

JAMES (cont'd)
And now we're going to be behind... and if we aren't able to get a good fucking lead actress then we're going to be way behind. And Bob is going to catch up, start filming, and get his shit out in theaters before we do.

GWEN
Is the idea of Bob getting ahead upsetting you?

JAMES
Yes! And I hate that it does, but it does! I don't like being jealous, Gwen, I really don't. It's an ugly emotion, but I really, just...***I*** was the one to end the partnership the way I did. And if I did that just so that he could excel then that means I left the most promising career path I could have had. It means that I was holding him back from being truly great. And that's some bullshit if it's true.

GWEN
That's not true, James. Even if Bob wraps filming before us, we're still going to end up with a full finished movie that's going to be just as good. We'll be alright. *You'll* be alright.

Gwen kisses James' on the cheek. James relaxes a bit.

JAMES
You're right. I've just got a lot on my mind right now and I want to get as much done tonight as I can. I'll feel better if I do.

GWEN
I understand, I'll make us some coffee.

Gwen walks back to the door. She pauses in the doorway on her way out.

GWEN (cont'd)
Don't give yourself a hernia working harder than you need to, James. You've got a whole team at your beck and call. Besides, there's no guarantee Bob will get ahead - if something this big can happen to us, anything could happen to him.

That sounds like a suggestion to James - a look of deep thought comes over his face as he wonder what all could go wrong with Bob's production.

JAMES
Yeah, I suppose you're right.

GWEN
Of course I am.

HOLD ON JAMES AS HE DWELLS ON THE THOUGHT.

INT. CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

CLOSE UP ON WHITE BOARD - DAYS TIL PRODUCTION: 31

A hand comes into frame and erases the 31 and writes the new answer as of today: 30.

Seats of the conference room are filled with Catherine, Gwen, Kenny, several writers, the AD and DP, and Susan.

James is missing. Catherine is getting impatient.

The clock ticks by.

CATHERINE
(whispering to Gwen)
Where the fuck is he?

GWEN
(snapping back)
I don't know!

CATHERINE
He's almost 20 minutes late.

GWEN
(correcting)
Almost 30.

Catherine shoots up from her chair and marches to the door.

CATHERINE
Jesus Christ, I'm calling him. Sitting here for 30 minutes and he's sulking, you know what that is?

Catherine puts her hand on the doorknob and addresses the room.

CATHERINE (cont'd)
Unprofessional!

The door swings open, slamming Catherine in the face. James is here holding an armful of files.

He has a big brown stain on his shirt.

Everyone in the room jumps up in shock - Susan stays in her seat and laughs uncontrollably.

JAMES
I'm here! I'm here! I'm sorry, I was taking care of something! What is everyone so panicked about?

Catherine groans - James notices her.

JAMES (cont'd)
Catherine! Oh my God, are you alright? What were you doing by the door?

Gwen helps Catherine up who has a big red mark on her face where the door hit her.

CATHERINE
WHERE HAVE YOU BEEN?

JAMES
I was taking care of something!

(Printed with the demonstration version of Fade In)

CATHERINE
What?!

James considers telling her...

BIG BAND MUSIC KICKS IN.

INT. JAMES' HOME - DAY - FLASHBACK

James is half naked on his living room floor writing and drawing like a madman.

He drinks straight from the coffee pot - it's too hot and he spills it and curses.

He waits a bit then sips slowly, it's fine now.

He has a thick stack of papers and folders of rewrites and concept art.

The landline rings - he snatches it up.

JAMES
HELLO?

RECEPTIONIST
Hi, Mr. Crane, I'm calling to remind you that you have a meeting today and-

JAMES
(Shrilly)
NOT NOW FELICITY!

RECEPTIONIST
Everybody is here and waiting for you. The meeting was supposed to begin about 3 minutes ago.

Beat.

JAMES
(Shrilly)
THANK YOU FELICITY!

He slams the landline down and starts rummaging up his papers.

HARD CUT TO:

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JAMES DRIVING

The engine is roaring and James is letting out one loud long "FU-U-U-U-CK!" to the open road as he speeds to the office.

END FLASHBACK.

INT. CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

We pick up where we left off with James and Catherine.

Gwen re-enters the room and hands Catherine an ice pack for her head.

JAMES (CONT'D)
I was doing locations scouting.

CATHERINE
LOCATIONS SCOUTING?

JAMES
(moving past her)
Everybody sit down please! I'll keep this brief!

People get settled back into their seats. Catherine holds the ice pack to her head.

James sets his files down and clears his throat.

JAMES (cont'd)
Alright! As you know, we've hit a pretty significant bump in the road with our lead dropping out.

ASSISTANT DIRECTOR
WHAT?!

JAMES
Okay, I see not everybody heard the news. Yes, Helen Royale will not be with us any more. Gwen and I worked out a plan in motion to get us a new lead by the end of next week. I also reviewed the script and a lot of the artwork that was done was inspired by or based around Helen. Some changes needed to be made.

James slides files to Susan, Kenny, and Catherine.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JAMES (cont'd)
They're not perfect but they're what we're working with. Let me know if you have any questions.

The three open their files.

Susan takes a look at some rough sketch art for wardrobe he'd like to see, as well as props and sets with highlighted colors he wants prominent throughout the film.

Kenny reads through some revised pages of dialogue written out by hand where lines of Martha (Helen's character) are rewritten.

Catherine looks through a revised budget and new requests.

CATHERINE
Sweet H. Christ, James where the hell are you getting these numbers?

JAMES
Without Helen, we'll be saving just shy of a million dollars. We can pay a fraction of that to whoever we get to play the lead instead and use the rest for bolder pursuits. Animatronics, puppets - I'm talking Jim Henson shit. Big elaborate sets that make our viewer feel like they're on another planet. Think Star Trek, think "A Trip to the Moon". People like the weird and whimsical, and if we do it right, in twenty-some years they'll be talking to their friends and kids about how "Satellite" was their childhood dream. We create iconography for today that will breed nostalgia for the future. In short, we're making lemon-zinger shots out of lemons. I spent last night thinking, crying, drinking, mourning over the loss of our lead - and I spent this morning getting over it. Everybody else ready to get over it?

Everybody in the room smiles and agrees.

JAMES (cont'd)
Gwen is going to be handling casting. Susan, I want your team working on making those drawings a reality.
(MORE)

JAMES (cont'd)
Kenny, I want those scribbles typed up into a cohesive draft of the script. Catherine, I want your green light on all this.

Catherine looks through the file once more - everyone watches quietly as she does.

CATHERINE
Let's do this shit.

JAMES
(more energized)
Let's do this shit.

Everyone feels a surge of enthusiasm and motivation - but everyone stays in their seats.

JAMES (cont'd)
No, now. People, we have a month before production starts we have to get this ball moving UP! Get up, get out, get to work! Now!

Everyone hurriedly stands up and starts rushing out the door.

JAMES (cont'd)
(Shrilly)
NOOOOOOOOOOWWWWW!

MONTAGE

Gwen is in an auditorium reading lines with 1 actress

2 actresses

3 actresses

4, 5, 6.

Number 7 is the one - ANNIE KEMPER.

PAN TO:

Susan and her art dept. are in the workshop.

Susan holds up an image of James' crudely drawn UFO - she moves the drawing out of frame to reveal the UFO being made practically with paper machete and scrap plastic.

PAN TO:

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

Kenny typing away at his typewriter furiously in a room with James.

Kenny peels a page of finished script from the typewriter and hands it to James who reads as he walks to the camera.

JAMES (cont'd)
I like this...I like this a lot!

PUSH CUT TO:

INT. POLICE STATION - DAY

PULL OUT FROM ACOUSTIC MEGAPHONE WITH A MOUTH IN THE MIDDLE.

JAMES
ACTION!

SLOWLY PAN PAST JAMES (in video village with Gwen / Kenny)- CREW - EQUIPMENT - UNTIL WE GET TO THE SCENE.

ANNIE
Please, please just listen to me...

OFFICER
I am listening to you, Ms. Briggs, but I'm telling you-

AS WE CLOSE IN - THE CREW MELTS AWAY AND WE SEE THE SCENE AS IT WILL BE SHOWN IN A TRUE 1970'S MOVIE THEATER:

GRAINY, NOISY AUDIO, BRIGHT COLORS.

ANNIE
(snapping)
I know!
(calming herself)
I'm sorry, I didn't mean to burst out. I'm under a lot of stress...I don't know what took my son. I only know that he was in bed that night - that there was a bright light and a loud noise coming from outside - and when I went to check on him again, he was gone. I don't know where he is, I don't know if he's okay, if he's looking for me, if he's...
(tearing up)
I know you can't make an official report on substantial evidence. But Pete, please. Please...I need to get my son back. If you can't do it, then can you *please* -
(MORE)

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

ANNIE (cont'd)
(angrily)
find me someone who will!?

Beat.

JAMES
CUT!

Annie and OFFICER break character and begin chattering like good friends.

Gwen shakes James' shoulders in excitement.

GWEN
I told you she would deliver - I fucking told you!

JAMES
She really is so talented.

James, Gwen, and DP watch the footage back.

JAMES (cont'd)
This is exactly how I pictured it.

DP
One more for safety?

JAMES
No, no, that was perfect. Perfect! Let's move on!

INT. JAMES' HOME - NIGHT

James is wearing comfortable clothes - plaid pajama pants and an oversized shirt.

He sips an "old fashioned" as he looks over the script on his couch.

The lamp behind him illuminates him alone in the room - as well as the landline on the coffee table next to him.

After a bit of reading, James sets the script down. He glances over at the landline - hesitates - then dials.

It rings for a minute before there's an answer:

BOB
(over the phone)
Bob Page.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JAMES
Hey Bob.

BOB
Oh! James?

JAMES
Yeah, how are you doing?

BOB
I'm...doing alright, staying busy. You actually caught me at one of the rare times I'm not running around doing a little bit of everything on this new film.

JAMES
Yeah, it's late so I figured I might be able to catch you.

BOB
You got me. What can I do for you?

Beat.

JAMES
(unsure)
I just wanted to check in. See how you're doing, see how your project is going.

BOB
I'm tired more than anything. But James, I really love this project. It's powerful, it's moving, it's important, it's beautiful. Marna is doing great stuff with what I wrote.

JAMES
Marna?

BOB
Oh, she's the director we have attached to the project. She's made it a priority to keep me involved in the process, it's very nice.

Beat.

JAMES
That is very nice. I'm trying to do the same with my lead writer Kenny, he's phenomenal.

WRITTEN WORK OF GAVIN WRAY

BOB
I bet.

JAMES
Tell me about this project, I've hardly heard anything.

BOB
Well, I can't say much. It's called "The Centurion", it's set in ancient Rome and follows a brave soldier who tries to preserve the life he's made for his family as the Roman Empire falls.

James takes notes as word-for-word as he can on the back of his script.

JAMES
Damn, Bob, working with some heavy topics there.

BOB
Yeah, James, it's what I'm best at.

JAMES
What are you talking about? You did great with the comedy.

BOB
(correcting)
It's what I *prefer*.

JAMES
Ah, I see. Well, how long until you start production?

BOB
It's coming up. Just a couple of days now. How about you? I, uh...heard you had a bit of a setback? Something about Helen Royale dropping out? I'm really sorry about that, James. That's terrible...

JAMES
Don't worry about it, it's not your fault. Besides, we've got someone better, for half the price, and we were able to start filming a few weeks ago.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

BOB
(surprised by this)
A few weeks ago? Even with that setback?

JAMES
Yeah, and I'll tell you Bob, it's a beautiful thing to see come together. Next week will be a bit dodgy though, we're filming without a permit in Gafferton, which is technically a "park" but their fees are insane and it's like a 10 second shot, so we'll have to be in and out.

Beat.

BOB
(bitterly)
Interesting. I hope that goes well for you.

James notices the tonal shift. And smiles.

JAMES
You jealous of me getting started on filming before you, Page?

BOB
No. No, you started your whole thing before me so it makes sense...I'm *happy* for you.

JAMES
Yeah. Yeah, I'm happy for you too, Bob. Keep up the good work. I look forward to hearing more from you.

James hangs up - giddy.

Bob sounded jealous of his work.

EXT. PRODIGY PRODUCTION STUDIOS - DAY

Bob is walking past the Production building to the sound stages in the back lot. He has a stern look on his face.

Marna drives up beside him in a golf cart.

MARNA
It's faster to drive. Would you like a ride?

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

BOB
Yes please.

Bob gets in - they drive down the lot.

MARNA
You look angry. Are you?

BOB
Not angry, no. Just...antsy. I'm ready to start production.

MARNA
Bobby, we still have a little while before that happens. Patience is a virtue.

BOB
Yeah, I know. I just feel hurried.

MARNA
Who's hurrying you?

BOB
Nobody.

MARNA
Is it your old friend? John?

They arrive at SOUND STAGE 3 and exit the golf cart.

The two walk into the sound stage and we see a practical set of a cave on a grassy hill. It's relatively small but very impressive.

Helen Royale and CENTURION are running lines with each other in the mouth of the cave.

BOB
James?

MARNA
James! Excuse me, yes. Is it James?

BOB
How do you know James?

MARNA
You two worked together for a while. Besides, I have connections. He's also working on a project of his own, yes?

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

BOB
Yes.

MARNA
And they've started filming already, yes?

BOB
(frustrated)
Yes.

MARNA
I see. Envy is a very ugly emotion, Bob. Nobody likes to look in the mirror when they'd rather be looking at someone else. My advice? If you'd rather not look in the mirror, look right in front of you instead, you'll still find lots of beauty, don't you think?

Bob gazes at the set. The cave looks very real - there are intricate details of Roman runes around the mouth.

There is a weathered looking banner of the Roman Empire atop it being adjusted by a couple workers in the art dept.

Helen Royale and Centurion look amazing in their outfits - they're laughing together.

It is all beautiful.

BOB
Right as usual, Marna.

MARTY
Although,

Bob jumps.

Marty has suddenly appeared beside Bob. Marty and Marna are on either side of him - the angel and devil on his shoulders.

MARTY (cont'd)
if you're gonna be jealous you could try to make sure the person you're jealous of doesn't have anything working envying. Catch my drift?

Bob considers this.

BOB
I think so.

CONNOR WRAY

Bob remembers what James told him over the phone.

BOB (cont'd)
Is there a landline here?

Without looking, Marty points off to the side.

Bob walks off screen in that direction.

Marna stares sternly at Marty.

It takes Marty a moment to realize.

MARTY
What?

MARNA
You're distracting him.

MARTY
I'm giving him an edge.

MARNA
(to the crew)
PICTURES UP IN 1 HOUR!

She marches forward into the set.

EXT. PARK - DAY

James and DP are walking through the park with a camera and a red cooler.

They get to a part lined with trees.

JAMES
Here's where I was thinking.

DP
I think that should work.

They walk to the trees. James sets the cooler down and takes out a grotesque alien egg, setting it down in the grass by one of the trees.

JAMES
How does that look?

DP looks through his camera.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

DP
I think that looks good. Are we just getting a still shot or are we moving at all?

JAMES
I was thinking we could be low to the ground - come around the corner from the back of the tree so the egg gets revealed to us.

DP
So movement?

JAMES
Yes, movement.

DP
Let's try it.

DP gets in position and starts filming.

WE SEE THE SHOT AS IT WILL BE IN THEATERS:

A slow push in on this narrow tree - with a strange and large green egg peaking out from behind it that becomes more and more visible the closer we get.

RANGER
Excuse me gentlemen.

The shot is interrupted.

James and DP look up to see a PARK RANGER standing behind them.

RANGER (cont'd)
I don't suppose you have a permit?

JAMES
No sir, we don't. But we're almost done here, we were just going to be in and out.

RANGER
In and out. I'm sorry, but you can't film or use footage from this park without a permit. You can get it and come back later today or tomorrow if you'd like.

JAMES
(sighing)
Thank you, we'll be out of here.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

Ranger does a double take of the alien egg before walking away.

DP
Shit, I thought we avoided the ranger post on the way out here.

JAMES
(thinking hard)
We did. I don't know how he knew we were out here.

DP
It's a slow day, we didn't pass anyone. I didn't tell anyone we were out here.

It clicks for James.

JAMES
I did.

DP
Who?

JAMES
It doesn't matter. Let's go to your house and film this scene in your back yard, ten seconds, and we'll be done for the day.

DP
Alright. It won't look as good as this, though.

JAMES
I know.

CUT TO:

EXT. BACK YARD - DAY

WE SEE THE SHOT AS IT WILL BE IN THEATERS:

A less gripping image of us creeping closer to a green slimy egg head on.

DP
We got it.

JAMES
Good work. I appreciate you.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

DP
Any time. You said that's all we need for today?

JAMES
Almost. Is that actors guild you were apart of a few years back still looking for some work to do?

DP
Which one? Actors Guild of America?

JAMES
No.

DP
Screen and Stage Actors Union?

JAMES
No.

DP
Stage Performers Guild?

JAMES
No.

DP
Talent united?

JAMES
That's the one.

DP
Yeah, I got it inside, I'll give you their number.

The two go inside.

EXT. PRODIGY PRODUCTION STUDIOS - DAY

Marty drives his convertible to the entrance of PPS and is halted by TALENT UNITED, they are on strike.

A slew of angry actors raving and holding signs boycotting "The Centurion".

Marty honks his horn.

MARTY
Ladies, what is all the hullaballoo? I need to get to work, can you please be the Red Sea for me and part?

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

ACTOR 1
THIS MOVIE IS WRONG! It's promoting fake history!

MARTY
It's a movie.

ACTOR 2
They're hiring only elite A-list actors and leaving nothing to starving artists like us!

MARTY
You don't look starving.

The crowd goes back to chanting "LET US WORK!" "LET US WORK!". They do not part.

Marty wraps around and parks on the street.

INT. SOUND STAGE 3 - DAY

Marna is talking to Helen Royale.

MARNA
I know they're being loud - we can't hear them with the microphones so I just need you to focus. Breathe, and focus.

HELEN ROYALE
Marna, I've told you I can't work in these hostile conditions. The yelling, the chanting, it's too much. We need to hold until they go.

MARNA
No we can't hold because they aren't going anywhere Helen.

Marty walks into the studio and up to Marna.

MARTY
Marna, what is happening out there? I couldn't get to my parking space I had to park my convertible on the street! In LA, Marna! That's like being naked in a nightclub with a sign on that says "rob me!"

MARNA
I'm sorry about your car - but I don't know, Marty.
(MORE)

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

MARNA (cont'd)
They showed up out of nowhere, they keep coming back 3 days now, I don't know how they heard about us or what they're so angry about. I've had a few people try to talk to them, I've tried to talk to them, nothing works. Now Helen is saying she can't perform.

MARTY
Helen, baby, you can't let these shmucks stop you! You're making art here!

HELEN ROYALE
I meant what I said. I'll be in my trailer.

Helen storms off.

MARTY/MARNA
(simultaneously)
Fuck!

INT. JAMES' CAR - DAY

James is wearing sunglasses. He is parked across the street from Prodigy Production Studios smiling as he sees the strike.

He checks his watch - then puts on a baseball cap, and grabs two fistfuls of fast food bags from the back seat.

EXT. PRODIGY PRODUCTION STUDIOS - DAY

James walks to the strikers and starts handing out bags of food.

JAMES
Well done, my starving artists. I'm going to need you to keep this up for a while.

ACTOR 1
How long?

JAMES
Until they pay you - and they *will* pay you. It might be one week, it might be two. Hell it might be a month.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

ACTOR 2
A month??

JAMES
You don't have to do this every day, just often enough to let them know you're here and you're mad and you're going to keep them from getting good work done. Easy enough, right?

ACTOR 1
Yeah, we can do that.

JAMES
That's why I love you guys. Eat good. Feel free to throw eggs at their cars if you got any.

ACTOR 2
Why would we have eggs?

JAMES
To throw at cars? I'll bring you eggs tomorrow.

James looks up and sees Helen Royale walking to a trailer. She is still in Oracle attire.

James is stunned.

JAMES (cont'd)
What the fuck?

ACTOR 1
What?

JAMES
WHAT THE FUCK?!

James pushes past the strikers and runs onto the lot.

JAMES (cont'd)
HELEN!

Helen doesn't hear James and walks into her trailer and shuts the door. Classical music is heard blaring from inside the trailer.

James approaches the trailer and sees "HELEN ROYALE: DAVINA / THE ORACLE - The Centurion".

James doesn't know what to say.

WRITER'S WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

He starts marching back through the lot trying to find someone to get answers out of.

JAMES (cont'd)
Who here works on Centurion? Who the hell is in charge?!

Marna drives out of sound stage 3 on a golf cart and halts in front of James.

MARNA
What do you want?

JAMES
Are you working on Centurion?

MARNA
I'm bringing it to life, I'm the director. What are you doing shouting and screaming and stomping all around my sound stage?

JAMES
How the hell did you guys get Helen Royale? She was ours. OURS! We had a CONTRACT!

MARNA
(confused)
I'm sorry? Ohhh, you're the producer for the project she was attached to before signing over..,

JAMES
The director slash conceptualizer.

MARNA
We got her because she changed her mind. There was a gap in your contract, and your planning, and we had a better offer. She liked it, she took it. Simple as that. Cruel maybe, unfair absolutely. Actors, right?

JAMES
Did Bob know about this?

MARNA
Bob Page? Of course.

JAMES
(scoffs)
Of course...Where is he? Is he on set today?

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

MARNA
He's inside work-shopping monologues for later scenes so he can't see you now but maybe in a few days.

JAMES
No, I think he'll be able to carve some time out of his busy schedule for me.

James starts speed-walking to the production office. Marna tries to block his path with the golf cart but James clamors over it and runs inside the building.

INT. PRODIGY PRODUCTION STUDIOS - DAY

James storms in and looks around the busy building.

JAMES
Bob? BOB? BOB?!

Bob peaks his head out of an office to see who is shouting. James notices him and points at him as he b-lines in his direction.

JAMES (cont'd)
What the hell is wrong with you? You knew that we had Helen Royale booked and you fucking took her from us? You didn't fight back? You didn't TELL me?

BOB
I see you're upset, I would be too...

JAMES
UPSET? Yeah, Bob, I'm fucking UPSET! Who the hell do you think you are!?

BOB
Is it really that big of an issue, James? Over the phone a while back you said everything was good! You got a new lead, scenes were perfect, you sounded happy!

JAMES
I HAVE TO BE HAPPY WITH IT, BOB! I HAVE HAD TO COMPROMISE ON EVERY GOD DAMN COCK-SUCKING THING!
(MORE)

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JAMES (cont'd)
EVERY STEP OF THE PROCESS HAS BEEN SECOND, THIRD, FOURTH, FIFTH, FUCKIN' NINETEENTH BEST CHOICE! NEVER THE FIRST!

People are beginning to stare.

Someone calls security.

BOB
I'm sorry that it's not going as well as you'd hoped, can we please talk about this away from people?

JAMES
No! I'm not done! Did you also call the Gafferton Park and tip them off that we were going to try and film there without a permit?

Beat.

The silence is enough for James to know.

JAMES (cont'd)
Oh my God, Bob. What the fuck is wrong with you?

BOB
What's wrong with me?! You were going to film without a permit, James! You don't do that! People need to get paid!

JAMES
For ten seconds of film? Go fuck yourself Bob! When the hell did you get so high and mighty?

BOB
I'm not high and mighty, I'm doing things the right way!

JAMES
No you're not, you're impeding on the way that *I* do things! Just because YOU don't see them as the right way! What if I said I didn't approve of you not hiring ground-level actors, huh?

(MORE)

WRITTEN WORK OF CW NORWAY

JAMES (cont'd)
What if I told you I think Helen Royale is dogshit and anybody from anywhere else working a fraction of her salary would do a thousand times better than anything she could ever do in any of your movies?

Beat.

Now Bob is angry.

BOB
Did you pay Talent United to boycot the Centurion?

JAMES
Yeah, and you know what? It was easy. So easy that I think I'll send more. And more. And even more the next week! Good luck finding any parking!

BOB
James, we're not doing anything wrong here!

JAMES
Maybe not but *I'M* just trying to do things the *right way!*

BOB
Oh, so we're being childish now?

JAMES
Don't call me childish.

James shoves Bob.

BOB
You've always been childish, James.

Bob shoves James.

JAMES
You've always been a stuck up, high and mighty, by-the-book, pain in the ass.

BOB
You've always been a self-centered, mid-tier, unoriginal, thoughtless, *childish*, moron.

Beat.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

James punches Bob in the face.

The two break out into an all out fight, wrestling all around the building.

They tumble over couches and chairs.

They run into the kitchen and knock over the coffee pot.

They tip over lamps and landlines.

Security comes in and tears them away.

They are both beaten up pretty badly.

JAMES
Fuck you, Bob! Your movie's never going to make it to theaters!

James walks out of the building.

EXT. PRODIGY PRODUCTION STUDIOS - DAY

James marches out of the building - rage and blood on his face. LOUD THUMPING BRASS AND PERCUSSION ACCOMPANY HIS ANGER.

He pushes past the strikers.

JAMES
Come back tomorrow. Come back every day! I'll pay you each $10 an hour!

ACTOR 1
Alright? You ok?

JAMES
NO!

James stomps to his car, gets in, and skirts away.

INT. REDBONE PRODUCTION STUDIOS - DAY

BACK SHOT OF A TATTERED AND BEATEN JAMES WALKING THROUGH THE BUILDING, CATCHING SHOCKED LOOKS FROM EVERYONE HE WALKS PAST.

BRASS AND PERCUSSION STILL THUMPING.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

INT. GWEN'S OFFICE - DAY

Gwen is speaking with Annie about "Satellite" when James walks in looking a mess.

Annie stands up.

GWEN
Jesus, James, are you alright? What the hell happened to you?

JAMES
It's unfriendly competition now.

BRASS AND PERCUSSION CRESCENDO.

CUT TO:

AN HOUR LATER

James has an ice back on his head and is wearing Gwen's jacket instead of his old ripped one.

Catherine, Susan, Kenny, and DP have all joined.

Everyone is chattering in a frenzy about the new news.

JAMES
We all hate Bob! Fuck him, fuck Prodigy, fuck The Centurion - that's not even a real name. You all know how badly I want to win. I want that best picture. I want best director, I want best screenwriter for Kenny, producer for Catherine, art dept. for Susan, best actress for Annie -

GWEN
(interjecting)
Is there a best casting director slash everything-else-gal award?

JAMES
I don't think so but if there was you would get it every year. The point is...Bob is our immediate competition. We cannot let him win. We have to do everything in our power not only to make sure our movie is perfect - but to make sure his is anything but. Does that sound good to everybody?

Everybody roars up in raged agreement.

KENNY
I'M GOING TO RIP HIS HEART OUT THROUGH HIS ASS AND MAKE HIM EAT IT!

Beat.

Everyone looks at Kenny.

Kenny gets bashful quickly.

KENNY (cont'd)
Sorry, you guys. I get passionate when I'm angry.

JAMES
No, no, that's good. Keep that energy.

KENNY
YEEEAAHHH!

EVERYONE
YEEEEEEAAHHH!

JAMES
Gwen, call your friend at EXTRA PULP, tell them we have a story.

INT. MARTY'S OFFICE - DAY

Marty is reading the latest issue of EXTRA PULP magazine with a crude illustration of a Roman soldier talking on a landline with a stupid expression on his face.

MARTY
(reading)
Not even a full month into production, "The Centurion" has already sparked outrage in Hollywood by playing dirty with the production studios, acting cruelly and unfairly to new blood actors, alleged blackmail and fraud. With a few first hand reports from insiders, people are calling it "soulless", "derivative", "amateur" and most potently: "stupid". I will be amazed if "The Centurion" is remembered beyond this article, let alone a century...

Bob and Marna sit across from Marty. Marna has her head in one hand as Marty finishes reading.

MARTY (cont'd)
What the hell is this? Who the hell wrote this and why? Bob? Does this have to do with that fight you had with that spazz in the lobby last week?

BOB
I don't know how but I'm sure...yes. James has connections, his connections have connections. I'm sure he knew someone who works for EXTRA PULP who got an article in.

MARTY
Not just an article, Bob! It's the main story! Everything else are underwear ads, grocery store coupons and housewife gossip about Shirly Eaton showing her tits in her latest movie - no one cares about those!

Marty holds up the magazine and shows him the cover again of the crude Roman soldier.

MARTY (cont'd)
THIS IS HOW PEOPLE ARE SEEING US BOB! WE CAN'T HAVE THAT!

BOB
I know, I'm sorry. I'll take care of it.

MARTY
No, Bob, *we're* going to take care of it. They say we're fighting dirty with other productions, then we will! Fuck this noise. You want those academy awards, don't you?

Bob and Marna nod.

MARTY (cont'd)
Me too. And when you win, you're both going to thank me in your acceptance speeches. But first, we need to make sure James' movie is unwatchable.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

EXT. SUBURBAN STREET - DAY

James is discussing the next shot with the DP.

In the background the Grip & Electric truck is parked on the street with two G&E workers smoking cigarettes nearby it.

Behind them, two people wearing dark clothes sneak up to the truck - climb in - and start driving away.

The G&E workers panic and run up to James and DP.

G&E 1
They're taking our shit!

JAMES
Fuck, BOB!

James, and the G&E guys chase after the fast moving-truck.

DP
(calling after them)
Should I come with you?

JAMES
(calling back)
KEEP SHOOTING!

MONTAGE OF:

1. BOB

Bob walks onto set while filming an indoor scene.

Marna is upset.

MARNA
They're saying we can't film.

BOB
Why not?

MARNA
The lenses - just look at them.

Bob takes a look at the lens on one camera - it's scuffed bad. He looks at another, it's also scratched horribly.

BOB
Good lord, that's going to be expensive...

MARNA
I know.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

2. JAMES

Outside James is getting ready to film a car scene.

Susan and DP are there. Annie is in the car.

JAMES
Alright Annie, you're just driving away out of frame, we'll probably get a few for safety and then we'll move on.

ANNIE
(calling back from the car)
Sounds good!

JAMES
Rolling...Action!

The car juts forward a few feet and then stops.

JAMES (cont'd)
Annie you just gotta keep driving.

ANNIE
It won't budge! I think it's out of gas!

JAMES
Who forgot to fill it up?

SUSAN
I did. Who emptied the tank?

JAMES
Fuck!

3. BOB

Filming in an old building decorated to look like a temple to Jupiter.

Marna and Bob are trying to get the perfect shot of CENTURION.

Outside, TALENT UNITED is chanting and boycotting loudly.

They cannot get the shot right.

4. JAMES

James walks into darkroom where someone is handling the film.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JAMES (cont'd)
How is it looking?

EXTRA
It's, uh...blank.

JAMES
What?

EXTRA
There's nothing here.

JAMES
Like it's ruined?

EXTRA
Like this was the wrong film.

JAMES
Someone gave you cannister 9? Marked "Satellite"?

EXTRA
Yeah.

James groans and leaves the room.

5. BOB

Bob gets in his car to drive to set. His tires are popped.

6. JAMES

James sits down with Catherine.

JAMES
We're going to need more money.

CATHERINE
How much?

James slides a piece of paper over to her.

CATHERINE (cont'd)
I can't read this.

JAMES
$25,000.

CATHERINE
WHAT?!

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

7. BOB

Outside Bob and Marna are filming a battle scene - closeup on Centurion.

MARNA
Ok, let's get this in one shot! Reset could take hours and we need it while the sun is up, let's go! A-game people! 3-2-1 Action!

Extras run behind Centurion as the scene commences.

MARNA (cont'd)
Cue catapult!

Nothing happens.

MARNA (cont'd)
Catapult! Catapult!

Nothing happens.

MARNA (cont'd)
Keep rolling. What the hell is happening?

A mini explosion goes off long after it was supposed to.

Marna swallows her rage.

MARNA (cont'd)
RESET!

8. JAMES

James walks onto set but half of the crew isn't there.

James calls Catherine.

JAMES
YOU'RE SUPPOSED TO BE HERE, YOU ALL ARE?

CATHERINE
(over the phone)
I GOT A DIFFERENT SCHEDULE THAN YOU!

JAMES
THERE IS NO DIFFERENT SCHEDULE, GOD DAMNIT!

9. BOB

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

Marna films a scene of Centurion sitting still and alone on a hillside with artificial wind blowing against him.

Nothing goes wrong. The shot is perfect.

INT. CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

James, Catherine, Gwen, Kenny, Susan & DP are all sitting together.

They are all tired and defeated.

JAMES
(groggily)
Listen up everybody. I know we're all exhausted. We've all been working hard these past few months. There's been a lot of sacrifice, a lot of hardship, a lot of struggle. But what we've managed to do so far looks really really good. We just need to push our way across the finish line with production these next two weeks and then it's over.

GWEN
Please...James, can you *promise* no more of this sabotage shit? It's so expensive and takes so long to fix.

Beat.

JAMES
I'm not going to sabotage anything. I'm done. I want the rest of my time to be dedicated to making this movie the best it can be. We're going to be in close proximity though - we need a bigger sound stage for these final shots in the UFO, so we're using Lot 9 at DYNAMO. From what I hear, "Centurion" is getting Lot 12, so they won't be far. But if we just keep our hands to ourselves, we'll be in and out. No trouble.

INT. MARTY'S OFFICE - DAY

Marty, Marna, and Bob all sit together - equally tired and defeated.

MARTY
We're in the homestretch now.

MARNA
They're going to be right by us in Lot 9. I have a few spare PA's ready to act as makeshift security if needed. They've got an important scene, we've got an important scene. I'm hoping everything stays civil. Bob...do you think they're going to try something?

Bob doesn't answer.

EXT. DYNAMO SOUND STAGES - DAY

Production teams for "Satellite" and "The Centurion" unload their equipment diagonally from each other.

James and Marna are guiding their crew to their respective areas to help get everything set up.

Bob is standing idly, watching everything move.

James notices Bob. Bob notices James.

Beat.

James holds up a peace sign with 2 fingers.

After a moments hesitation, Bob responds with the same peace sign. Bob smiles.

James smiles back, nods, and walks into his soundstage.

Once James is gone, Bobs smile drops and he walks into his soundstage.

INT. SOUND STAGE 9 - DAY

We are inside an enormous UFO. The scene is set with Annie in weathered clothing - standing next to a small practical effect cicada-like alien.

A child actor playing her son is next to a makeshift pod filled with strange goop.

James is talking to Annie.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JAMES
Alright, this is the "big moment", right? This whole time, Martha has been looking for her son, for Hank. There he is. He's somewhere weird and dangerous but he looks alive and relatively well. You've both been through so much to get here, you've learned so much. And now, there he is. And you know everything is going to be okay because he has you and you have him again...Just try to really get in touch with that.

ANNIE
I love it...tears, you think?

JAMES
Some. I think when Hank is unconscious in your arms it's okay to shed some tears but once he comes to - once he says "mommy?", that's when you wipe them away. You need to be strong in front of him, right?

ANNIE
I like that, I think I can do that.

JAMES
I know you can, you're going to do great.

ANNIE
Thank you.

James walks back to video village, just outside of the UFO.

Everyone gets in place.

JAMES
Everybody ready? Let's get this!

AUDIO
Sound speeding. Mic is hot.

DP
Camera speeding.

MARKER
Scene 65, take 1, marker!

Clack!

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JAMES
And...action.

The scene commences:

WE SEE THE SCENE AS IT WOULD BE IN THEATERS:

Annie warily approaches the Pod her son is suspended in - the alien moving next to her.

ANNIE
(to the alien)
That's...that's him, I'm sure of it.

ALIEN
Good...

ANNIE
Can you...can you let him go? Can you give him back to me?

Beat.

ALIEN
Yes...

The alien lifts one of its strange buggy hands and slices open the pod. The child slumps forward and is caught by Annie.

Annie cradles the child in her arms - first examining him. Slowly, she brings her ear to his chest and waits until she hears it: a heartbeat.

She breaks down - pulling the child into an embrace.

ANNIE
(crying)
Oh my God...Hank, it's you. It's really you. You're alive. Thank God, you're alive...I'm so sorry, I'm so sorry I wasn't there but I'm here now. Mommy's here for you, honey.

HANK
(groggily)
Mommy?

Annie wipes away her tears.

ANNIE
Yes! Yes, baby, it's me, it's mommy.

Annie smiles at the child, now awake.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

ANNIE (cont'd)
Everything's going to be okay. We're going to go home, okay? We're going home.

CLOSE SHOT ON ANNIE AND HANK.

CUT TO A CLOSE SHOT ON THE ALIEN:

ALIEN
(dreamily)
Going...home...

Beat.

James looks like he's about to tear up.

JAMES
(choking)
Cut!

The crew applauds.

JAMES (cont'd)
That was so good. Absolutely amazing.

DP
You think it's good?

JAMES
I think it's perfect.

INT. SOUND STAGE 12 - DAY

Bob is walking through the sound stage around the set prepared for the scene.

It is a beautiful replication of a Roman temple. Gold, marble, pillars, mosaics, olive branches and wreaths, incense, etc.

Everything looks and smells like it's authentic to the time.

Bob takes in every intricate detail:

The box curves - the real grapes - the bust of Mars - the flickering torches.

Marna approaches behind him.

MARNA
You approve?

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

BOB
How could I not? You brought everything I wrote down to life - and then some.

MARNA
I work hard, Bobby. And it pays off.

BOB
It really does. You outdid yourself Marna. This is absolute amazing work.

MARNA
Let's see how it looks on screen.

WE CUT BACK AND FORTH BETWEEN SOUND STAGES.

MARNA WORKING WITH HELEN / JAMES WORKING WITH ANNIE.

BOB WATCHING HIS WORDS COME TO LIFE THROUGH HELEN AND CENTURION / JAMES SEEING THE CONCEPT ART MADE REALITY.

WE SEE PARTS OF SCENES AS THEY WILL BE SHOWN IN THEATERS OF EITHER FILM - INTER-SPLICED WITH ONE ANOTHER.

In these moments, Bob and James are both overwhelmed. They love their work.

INT. SOUND STAGE 9 - DAY

James and his team have just finished a scene of Annie, Hank, and the alien running down the hall of the UFO.

JAMES
(calling out)
CUT! Good, moving on!

The DP joins James.

DP
I think for this next scene we could do something fun with the lighting - make the scene look almost entirely green with the lights.

JAMES
Oh, I like that. Let's do a sample first before we commit to it.

DP
(walking away from James)
I need grip and lighting!

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

Gwen walks over to James.

GWEN
How's it going?

JAMES
Really really good, actually. You like the shots?

GWEN
I love them. Do you?

JAMES
I do. Why are you talking to me like that?

GWEN
Like what?

JAMES
Like you're worried I'm not happy with them.

GWEN
It's been a brutal year of pre-production and production, James, I'm just checking in. I really like what we've got, especially if you're satisfied with them.

JAMES
I'm more than satisfied.

GWEN
Good, you should be.

We hear the obnoxious beeping of a large truck backing into the sound stage.

James and Gwen look up - an entire second film crew is here.

James runs up to them.

JAMES
Excuse me. Excuse me! You guys can't be here, we have this stage until midnight, we still have like eight hours.

A man carrying a clipboard checklist walks up to James.

CLIPBOARD
You sure? Stage 9 - DYNAMO?

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JAMES
Yeah, "Satellite" - Stage 9, DYNAMO, August 19th.

James pulls a paper out of his back pocket that confirms this.

CLIPBOARD
Interesting...

CLIPBOARD turns his clipboard around to face James - it's the same stage, same date, but a different project.

JAMES
What the fuck? We got clearance from DYNAMO saying we have this all day.

CLIPBOARD
We could share? You get the right half, we take the left?

JAMES
We have a whole fucking UFO taking up the damn sound stage, we can't split it. Please tell your people to stop moving stuff in!

CLIPBOARD
Who did you talk to about this booking and when?

JAMES
My producer - Catherine Monroe called and spoke to Joey Kiln, he's second in charge under Mickey. We have all the paperwork, we can confirm everything. Who did you talk to?

CLIPBOARD
We spoke on the phone with a "Robert".

James' face drops.

JAMES
You've gotta be fucking kidding me...

GWEN
James, what's happening?

JAMES
Fucking Bob again.

GWEN
Are you serious?!

JAMES
Yes.

CLIPBOARD
Am I missing something?

JAMES
Please just wait where you are!

CLIPBOARD
I can't just wait, I've got a whole truck full of shit I need to start moving, a whole crew to order around, a whole movie to shoot!

GWEN
What movie?

CLIPBOARD
"Wrath of the Angry Possums 4: Hungrier"

GWEN
Abso-fucking-lutely not.

DP
(calling across the room)
What's going on?

JAMES
BOB!

The cast and crew of "Satellite" all burst out into frustrated roars and curses.

Even Hank says "motherfucker!"

THE THUMPING BRASS AND PERCUSSION KICK IN AGAIN.

James storms off set.

JAMES (cont'd)
(calling back)
MAKE SURE THESE PEOPLE DON'T SET UP ANYTHING!

James runs up to someone driving a golf cart between sound stages.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JAMES (cont'd)
Excuse me, I need to borrow this.

James wrestles with the person driving the golf cart until they are out and he is in the drivers' seat.

He speeds over to stage 12.

INT. SOUND STAGE 12 - DAY

Helen Royale and Centurion are in the middle of an scene of close dialogue - speaking in hushed tones.

This is quickly interrupted by the loud hum of a golf cart barreling into the room - and running into the set, crumpling a large portion of it.

Many cast and crew jump in horror at this, including Bob.

James backs up and rams into the set again and again, leaving a large dent in the once perfect set piece.

He then backs up further before driving into various fresnel lights and cameras propped up on tripods - knocking them over and breaking them.

Once the bulk of his damage is done - James does donuts.

BOB
JAMES, WHAT THE HELL IS WRONG WITH YOU?!

James jumps out of the golf cart and rushes Bob - grabbing him by the collar.

JAMES
ONE WEEK, BOB? YOU COULDN'T LEAVE ME ONE FUCKING WEEK? YOU KNOW HOW MUCH MONEY THIS SHIT COSTS - LET ALONE RESHOOTS, REPAIRS, RECASTS, REWRITES!

James keeps hold of Bob's collar and pushes him back against the model pillar - a torch hanging nearby - illuminating them.

JAMES (cont'd)
What's wrong with ME?! What the hell is wrong with YOU, BOB!?

BOB
I just want to make my movie!

JAMES
No you don't Bob! You *don't* want me to make *my* movie! You don't give a shit about this - you don't give a shit about any of it! You never have! You write your bitter fucking crocodile-tear-jerking Shakespearean tragedies, and then I have to come in and save the day by reminding you: The world isn't that bad, Bob! YOU'RE ONE OF THE RICHEST PEOPLE IN HOLLYWOOD - YOU ARE NOT SUFFERING! You are not a tortured artist! You don't have a choked voice that needs to be heard! You're a pretentious, arrogant bastard who feels silenced by the world because he never feels like contributing to the conversation!
You see, me, Bob? I LOVE THIS! I love all of it! I came out here with nothing so that I could do this! I want to see people move on screen - I want to make people laugh and cry! I want to make people go to the movies and think they can make people laugh and cry too! Make them think they can connect to people in a human way that so many of us are so damn scared to do!
You're doing this because you want to win, Bob, you're doing this out of bitter poison spite! You don't GET IT! You never have!
I want to win too! I'm doing this because I NEED TO! I can't see myself doing anything else with my life! I never have!
And you just don't GET IT!

Marna grabs James by the shoulder to try and pull him away.

MARNA
That's enough!

Gwen's hand appears on Marna's shoulder - Marna turns to see who it is and is met with a punch in the face.

Many of the cast and crew of "Satellite" has bled over into the set of "The Centurion".

Brawls break out left and right.

Grip and Electric fight each other.

Sound people duel with boom poles.

Lighting people throw light bulbs at each other.

Actors rip at each others' costumes.

Producers throw fists.

Bob and James wrestle.

EXT. DYNAMO SOUND STAGES - DAY

The sounds of 2 film productions battling rages on.

Several police vehicles pull into the lot with the lights flashing and sirens blaring.

INT. CONFERENCE ROOM - NIGHT

A single warm light illuminates James and Gwen at the table. They're both holding bags of ice - James to his shoulder - Gwen to her head.

James is pitifully staring off into nothing.

They are both bruised and cut up - hair and clothes disheveled.

There is a boombox between them playing "Sonata No. 42 in D Minor" (Mozart).

JAMES
(groggily)
What is this?

GWEN
Mozart. I always keep a tape in my desk drawer.

JAMES
Why?

GWEN
In case I need to mellow out of my rage.

The tape skips. Gwen shakes the boombox and it plays normally again.

JAMES
Sounds pretty old.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

GWEN
Yeah, I use it a lot.

JAMES
Oh. That's a good idea.

Beat.

JAMES (cont'd)
I really thought you were going to kill that sound lady.

GWEN
I wanted to James. I really really wanted to.

JAMES
She looked so much like Leonard Nimoy.

Gwen shakes her ice bag - it's melted into water.

GWEN
I'm going to replace my ice, do you need a change too?

JAMES
No, I'm good. Thank you.

Gwen stands and moves to the door. As she's about to leave, James sniffles - stifling tears.

Beat.

GWEN
James?

JAMES
(quickly)
I'm ok. I'm ok, Gwen, really. I'm sorry.

Gwen moves back to him and places a hand on his cheek.

He looks up at her.

GWEN
James...

JAMES
I'm ok, Gwen. I will be ok.

Gwen kisses him.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

GWEN
I'm really proud of you James.

They embrace one another and sigh deeply.

JAMES
Thank you, Gwen. I really appreciate all of your hard work.

GWEN
Anytime.

She kisses his head and walks out of the room.

James sits alone for a while with Mozart playing.

He shuts his eyes and breathes deeply, calming himself.

He turns off the music.

BOB
Why'd you turn it off?

James jumps in his seat. He turns to see Bob standing in the doorway, also bruised and cut but wearing comfortable clothes.

JAMES
Jesus Christ, where the fuck did you come from?

BOB
I only got in a minute ago.

JAMES
God, you're like Nosferatu. Skulking around in the dark like that, I couldn't even hear your footsteps.

BOB
I didn't want to disturb you.

JAMES
I'm very disturbed, Robert. What do you want?

BOB
To talk. To apologize. To explain. Is that ok?

James nods at a chair next to him for Bob to sit in.

Bob sits.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

BOB (cont'd)
You hurt?

JAMES
Yeah. You?

BOB
Oh yeah.

They both nod and smile, proud of themselves.

BOB (cont'd)
Even though you're not a writer, you delivered a hell of a speech. It was very moving.

JAMES
Bob, don't fucking mock me right now.

BOB
(reassuringly)
No, no! James, I'm not trying to mock you, I swear!

James sits back and gestures for Bob to continue.

BOB (cont'd)
What you said was true. When you and I did our work, I didn't...care. I didn't care. I would write the stories, you would change them into movies that would succeed at the box office, and I only cared about my part in the work, everything else was nonsense to me.
But then I started working on The Centurion. And it started as spite. Something to show you "I can make it on my own too". But then it became real. Marna showed me what she could do with my story. We made plans. We got Helen Royale. We filmed so many beautiful moments. I saw ancient Rome be built and fall right in front of me, it was like magic, James.
Did I ever tell you what The Centurion was about?

JAMES
Not really, no.

BOB
A decorated Roman soldier, Titus. He, his wife, and his daughter, all live comfortable lives of wealth and frequent responsibility. One day, Titus is summoned to meet with an old woman; an Oracle. The Oracle tells Titus that Rome will fall. Everything he's worked for, everything he's come to know - the comfort, the stability, the reputation, it's all going away and there's nothing he can do. Titus doesn't like this. He tries to warn people, he tries to ignore the signs, he fights. In the end, nothing works. All he can do is take care of his loved ones. They have to leave Rome to let itself crumble, and they find beautiful refuge in the north, by the sea. They don't have Rome anymore, but they have each other.

JAMES
That's a damn good story, Bob.

BOB
It is. Loosely inspired by real life.

JAMES
I figured. Our dual career is Rome, it sounds like? You're Titus.

BOB
Yeah.

JAMES
Am I the old woman that tells you that your career is going to hell?

BOB
I suppose so, yes.

JAMES
Does that make your scripts your wife and daughter?

BOB
It's loosely inspired.

JAMES
Right.

WRITTEN BY CONNOR WRAY

BOB
I wrote that story. 130 pages. I got Marna and Helen. And once the cameras were up, it was the most important thing in my life. I wanted to show up every day and watch the actors go. I wanted to see the props waving around and the set pieces just...being. And I had to make sure nothing took that away from me.

JAMES
Bob, I was never trying to take anything away from you. I had my Rome too, but I told myself it was time for it to fall so I could take my... Oracle family to go to...where?

BOB
England, it's not a great metaphor, let's drop it.

JAMES
I got comfortable, Bob. I fell into a routine and I felt like I was doing the same thing over and over again. And it was great, it raked in the money, I got to work with good people. But it felt like a job, and I got bored, Bob. I got so bored of it. I needed to switch things up, get back to what I love, make something I really care about, you know?

BOB
I know, James. It was business, and I took it personally.

JAMES
When we've worked together for so long, business and personal are indistinguishable. Whatever the matter was, I handled it wrong.

BOB
Me too.

JAMES
So we're both bad at our jobs.

They smile at one another.

Beat.

BOB
I'm sorry, James.

JAMES
I'm sorry too. How would you feel about a truce for post-production? Mutual no sabotage. No stealing reels, no burning footage, no graffiti on billboards and posters.

BOB
That sounds good to me.

The two stand and hug each other.

Bob looks over James' shoulder at the doorway.

BOB (cont'd)
I'm sorry to you too, Gwen.

Gwen is standing in the doorway with a fresh new bag of ice on her forehead.

GWEN
You're alright, Bobby. Let me listen to Mozart this weekend and we'll be all good.

BOB
Alright.

Gwen turns the music back on. Mozart continues.

INT. RECORDING STUDIO - DAY

Bob and Marna walk into a recording studio with an entire orchestra waiting for them. Marna is carrying a briefcase.

Bob and Marna are still recovering from their wounds from the sound stage brawl.

An older woman, the CONDUCTOR stands to greet them. The SOUND MIXER is sitting at a table full of audio equipment, getting everything prepared.

CONDUCTOR
Mr. Page! Ms. Orville, welcome! I'm very excited to show you what we've been working on.

MARNA
We're very excited to hear, Ms. Meuler.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

CONDUCTOR
Please, take a seat by Argyle, our recording artist.

Bob admires the orchestra and waves as he and Marna sit by Argyle, the Sound Mixer. Marna opens the briefcase and pulls out script copies.

SOUND MIXER
I got a call from Marty this morning. Are we expecting any unwelcome visits from another production studio?

Marna looks at Bob.

Bob doesn't take his eyes off the orchestra.

The Conductor warms up the orchestra.

BOB
No, we're alright.

Marna nods at the Sound Mixer.

SOUND MIXER
Ms. Meuler? We're ready whenever you are.

CONDUCTOR
We're ready.

Marna leans into a microphone on the table.

MARNA
Recording for scene 19-A. The beginning of the battle.

Sound Mixer presses record.

A large projection appears on the wall above the orchestra - the film is about to begin.

3...2...1...

The band plays - music swells filling the room.

The projection shows an incredible scene of Roman soldiers preparing for a battle.

We see another army preparing.

The music accompanies the footage beautifully as both armies collide.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

- FILM TRAILER -

A bright red tattered flag on a battle field.

A bright red flag waves on a white pillar.

A bright red flag on a bell tower.

A bright red flag in front of a temple.

NARRATOR
The most powerful empire in the world...

The Emperor holding his arms up triumphantly to his people.

NARRATOR (cont'd)
Made strong by the blood, sweat, and pride of their boldest warriors.

A golden army of Roman soldiers standing on a tall hill - lightning flashing behind them.

NARRATOR (cont'd)
The Centurions.

The Centurion army battling the Saxons.

NARRATOR (cont'd)
But not even they,

Titus riding to the Oracle's cave.

Titus meeting the Oracle - the Oracle smiling grimly at Titus.

NARRATOR (cont'd)
Can stop what's coming.

ORACLE
Rome...will fall.

Titus raving at the Roman Forum to a crowd.

Davina slides a knife out of her sleeve.

Davina and Titus standing together in a room full of bodies.

NARRATOR
When the end comes for Titus of Rome and his family.

Titus pressing his forehead to his daughter's forehead.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

NARRATOR (cont'd)
Will he find a way to save those he loves most?

Titus raising a sword high in the air.

TITUS
FOR ROME!

CENTURION ARMY
FOR ROME!

TITLE CARD. - "THE CENTURION"

NARRATOR
The Centurion. Releases this fall.

- FILM TRAILER -

A child's bedroom at night. A bright light shines through the window.

NARRATOR
They came from another world.

The child is being lifted out of his bed to the light.

NARRATOR (cont'd)
No one knows how. No one knows why.

Annie enters the bedroom and sees that its empty.

ANNIE
Hank?

NARRATOR
And nobody knows who "they" are.

Annie in the police precinct.

ANNIE
I don't know if he's okay, if he's looking for me, if he's...
(tearing up)
I know you can't make an official report on substantial evidence. But Pete, please. Please...I need to get my son back. If you can't do it, then can you *please* -
(angrily)
find me someone who will!?

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

NARRATOR
But she...

Multiple shots of Annie getting geared up in a flight suit.

NARRATOR (cont'd)
Is about to find out.

Annie standing before a giant alien door opening to reveal smoke and bright white light.

TITLE CARD. - "SATELLITE"

NARRATOR (cont'd)
Satellite. Releases this fall.

INT. MOVIE THEATER - DAY

SATELLITE is playing on the big screen. Annie is exploring a large spaceship - the one we saw on the soundstage.

Only on screen, it looks real.

We see the back of a mans head watching the movie.

SLOWLY PUSH IN AND TURN TO SEE : BOB.

He's eating malt balls and watching intently - smiling.

EXT. MOVIE THEATER - DAY

The sun will be setting soon.

Bob exits the movie theater with the rest of the audience - everyone is chattering about it.

Bob walks past 2 adjacent posters on the outside of the movie theater:

SATELLITE & THE CENTURION

Both of which say "OSCAR NOMINEE".

EXT. HIGHHWAY - DAY

The sun is setting.

Bob is driving along the highway and passes several billboards for SATELLITE and THE CENTURION.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

(Printed with the demonstration version of Fade In)

INT. ART DEPARTMENT - DAY

James is standing with his team - Susan, Kenny, Gwen, and Catherine.

There are several poster designs for SATELLITE behind James.

JAMES
I saw the billboards and I'm very happy. We're halfway through our theatrical run and already we've got good reviews across the board. Empire, MTV, The Guardian, they all love us.

Gwen holds up her hand.

GWEN
I had a meeting with Hasboro on Monday. They're interested in making an action figure line with the characters. Hank, Martha, Jubo, the spaceship, the works.

JAMES
That's huge! Amazing work, Gwen! What else are we working with?

CATHERINE
Our actors have been on a really successful press tour. We got them with Mike Douglass and Johnny Carson. They're killing it.

JAMES
Music to my ears, Catherine. Anything else?

SUSAN
Our sales for Satellite posters have been pretty good.

JAMES
"Pretty good", great. Kenny, you got anything?

KENNY
A very pretty reporter asked if she could talk to me about the writing process and I blacked out but she said I was very well spoken.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JAMES
Alright...I guess we'll see if that's a win whenever your article comes out.

Kenny holds two thumbs-up.

JAMES (cont'd)
We just need to keep this going. We're on an award campaign streak now. Best Picture. So we need to advertise it like a high quality, high class movie. Like it's already a classic. What do we got?

Everybody raises their hands and starts prattling off ideas over each other. James writes on a white board.

INT. PRODIGY PRODUCTION STUDIOS - DAY

Bob is sitting at a type writer in a room by himself - he's staring at the page intently with his hands clasped together under his nose.

The page reads:

INT.

And nothing else.

There's a knock at the door. Bob looks up to see who it is - Marty.

MARTY
Am I catching you at a bad time?

BOB
No, not at all. What can I do for you, Marty?

MARTY
Well, you can put some more words on those pages, but first you can celebrate with me.

BOB
Celebrating what?

MARTY
We're up for the award.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

BOB
Best Original Screenplay? I know, Marna called to tell me a while ago.

Marty shakes his head.

BOB (cont'd)
Best actress? Helen?

MARTY
Best Picture, Bobby. We could be going home from that award show with everything.

Bob stares at Marty in awe.

BIG BAND MUSIC KICKS IN.

EXT. AWARD SHOW - NIGHT

BRIGHT FLASHING LIGHTS.

GOLD ACCENTS, BLACK SUITS AND DRESSES, RED CARPETS AND CURTAINS.

POSTERS OF FILMS.

PAPARAZZI.

We see a cameraman focused on a REPORTER.

LOOKING THROUGH THE LENS.

REPORTER
We're here at the 52nd Oscar Award Ceremony where we have already seen so many bright beautiful people walking in. We've had Sally Field pass by as well as Mickey Rooney. We're still seeing personalities walk in now - oh, here's one! Mr. Page! Mr. Page, how are you doing?

Bob looks like a deer in headlights as he's stopped by the reporter.

BOB
(awkwardly)
I'm well. I'm doing very well, I'm very excited to be here.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONWORKWAY

REPORTER
I'm sure! Not your first time at the Oscars but your first time for a project *outside* of your duo, is that right?

In the background, we see a blurry James talking to another reporter getting pictures taken of him.

BOB
That's, uh...yes, that's right. I worked with a team quite different from my norm. But evidently it worked out very well for me, everyone was delightful to work with.

REPORTER
Oh, I saw the movie. Absolutely incredible.

BOB
Thank you.

REPORTER
What lead to you splitting off from your duo? Is there any bad blood?

James notices Bob and walks up quietly behind him - smiling.

BOB
Uh, no I don't think there's any bad blood, I'd say. Not on my end. We both just had some passion projects we wanted to do on our own. We wanted to prove to ourselves we weren't one-trick-pony's, as it were. We hold ourselves to a high standard and if we deliver anything less we're not only failing *ourselves*, but we're failing you.
(he turns to the camera and points to the audience)
We're failing *you*.

REPORTER
Beautifully said.

BOB
Thank you.

James puts his hands on Bob's neck and throttles him - pretending to strangle him. Bob is surprised and struggles against this.

James lets him go and puts an arm around his shoulder, laughing.

JAMES
(happily)
No one can say it better than this man, he really is the best at what he does. I'd say tied with my good friend, Kenny McFarlane. But there absolute is bad blood, this lunatic threw so many wrenches in my production I thought we weren't going to get it done.

Bob goes white - he feels like he's being told on.

REPORTER
Really?

BOB
Well, y-yes, but it was all to make sure everything was...

JAMES
It was all in good fun! I got him back though - I drove a golf cart through his set. If you watch the movie and you see a weirdly shaped dent in the cave of the Oracle, that's all me.

REPORTER
Wow! It sounds like you two still managed to have a lot of contact even working separately.

Gwen appears behind James and takes his arm, gesturing that they need to go inside.

JAMES
Always, I'm looking forward to the next round of filming we do apart. I've already got plans. I'll see you inside!

James and Gwen walk away. Bob looks on after him.

OUT OF LENS.

Bob watches James and Gwen walk into the award show, shaking hands with people, hugging others, talking to one another.

James looks back at Bob and holds up a peace sign with his fingers.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

Bob smiles and holds up a peace sign with his.

BOB
(to Reporter)
Thank you.

Bob walks into the award show.

INT. CEREMONY VENUE - NIGHT

An enormous room full of people in suits and dresses.

A large stage with a single microphone in the center and a big screen behind.

Rows of round tables and seats with friends and teams sitting together.

James, Gwen, Catherine, Susan, and Kenny are sitting together.

Bob, Marty, and Marna are sitting together as well.

A woman in a silver glittering dress is talking about best special effects on stage.

Bob is tapping his leg aggressively.

MARTY
Jesus, Bobby, did you take a bump of snow in the bathroom? Your leg is moving like a car engine.

BOB
I'm just nervous. There's not many awards left until Best Picture. What if we don't win?

MARTY
Relax, it's practically in the bag.

BOB
But you told me Academy Awards are a social game. The more people you know the better chance you've got. I hardly know anybody here, Marty.

MARTY
Then you'd better hope your work makes up for that.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

MARNA
Robert. You did good work. So did I, so did everyone on our project. I know that, and you should too. Whatever happens, happens. We'll go home knowing we were here. We ate well, drank well, and had good company. Can you agree?

Bob nods.

MARNA (cont'd)
Excellent. Have more champagne, it'll loosen you up.

Bob pours himself more champagne.

People applaud as SUSAN walks off stage holding her award for Best Special Effects.

Susan rejoins her table.

GWEN
Congratulations, Susan!

SUSAN
Thanks! Oh my god, did I do alright up there? Did I ramble?

GWEN
I don't think so.

SUSAN
Oh, good. I'm *so drunk,* Gwen.

GWEN
That's ok, Suze. We're getting a limo home.

SUSAN
YES!

GWEN
(to James)
How are you feeling?

James is going back and forth between sipping champagne and scribbling down something on a napkin.

JAMES
I'm doing great.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

GWEN
That's it? Great? You're not stressing or anything? Are you panic-writing a last minute speech in case you win?

JAMES
What? No. Here, take a look.

James slides the napkin over to Gwen.

She holds it up and reads what's on it.

GWEN
What's this?

JAMES
The next big thing we're working on. Bob inspired me a little, I think a period piece could be fun. You wanna be there for it?

James holds out his hand. Gwen smiles and takes his hand.

GWEN
Of course.

James kisses her hand.

The SPEAKER in the silver dress is back on stage.

The music gets low and tense.

SPEAKER
We are now going in to our last five awards for the night. Best actor, best actress, best original screenplay, best director, and finally: best picture. Starting with best actor: the nominees are: Brian Dee in "Lincoln". Ken Hamilton in "Free Ride". Jud Moore in "Letters from the Front Line", and Jack Tank in "The Weight of Gold"...and the winner is...Ken Hamilton, for "Free Ride"!

People applaud. James takes a sip of champagne - Bob looks over at James.

JUMP FORWARD
TO:

SPEAKER (cont'd)
May Roh in "Gone Blind". Rosaline Kemp in "Wilder". Helen Royale in "The Centurion". And Annie Seever in "Satellite". And the winner is... Annie Seever, for Satellite!

Annie jumps up from a table she's sitting at with her family and runs on stage, ecstatic.

JUMP FORWARD TO:

SPEAKER (cont'd)
Bob Page for "The Centurion". Josh Kroll for "Hive Mind". Yue Ji for "Gone Blind". And Kenny McFarlane for "Satellite"...the winner is...Kenny McFarlane, "Satellite"!

Kenny's smile drops as he hesitantly walks up to the stage. He's bewildered that he won.

JUMP FORWARD TO:

SPEAKER (cont'd)
James Crane for "Satellite". Marna Orville for "The Centurion". Dennis Culver for "Lincoln". And Ellen Joy for "The Weight of Gold"...and the winner is...Marna Orville, "The Centurion"!

Gwen and Kenny pat James on the shoulder. James shrugs, unbothered.

JUMP FORWARD TO:

Music is no longer playing. The entire room is silent.

SPEAKER (cont'd)
Our final award of the night...The 52nd Oscars nominees for Best Picture are: "Gone Blind". "Hive Mind". "Satellite". And "The Centurion"... and the winner for Best Picture is..."The Centurion"!

CELEBRATORY MUSIC PICKS BACK UP!

Bob's mouth hangs open. Marty and Marna grab either arm of his and hoist him up, pulling him on stage.

CONNOR WRAY

The Speaker hands Bob the Oscar. It's golden and beautiful.

Bob looks up to see a crowd applauding him. Confetti falls from the ceiling.

Bob looks down at the microphone.

BOB
I-I want to thank you all so much for this honor. I put a lot of love and care into this script. As well as a lot of frustration and bitterness. All the emotions, all the passion I feel for this medium...I can't describe it. It's an unbelievable feeling and - and you chose us! The best team I could ask for! So thank you, all of you, thank you! And thank you as well to the talented team of "Satellite", without their work we would not have been motivated enough to make "The Centurion" what it is. So James, Catherine, Gwen, everyone - thank you. Thank you all! I hope I can keep it up so that I can find myself back here again.

Bob steps back and lets Marna take the mic.

MARNA
You all have been absolutely incredible. I look forward to working with Bob and Marty more in the future - so keep us in mind for the coming years. Thank you all, you're all such lovely people.

Everyone applauds. James stands and claps - Bob notices and holds up his award while looking at James as if to say "Look!".

Closing music plays as people begin to leave the ceremony.

EXT. AWARD SHOW - NIGHT

People are walking out of the show. Bob makes his way out with his award, nodding to people and shaking their hands in thanks and congratulations until he finds himself on the sidewalk.

Mirroring the opening scene - Bob stands on a sidewalk alone with his award. There's no one for him to celebrate with.

Beat.

Marna sets herself beside Bob.

MARNA
Why do you look so pitiful?

BOB
I wasn't trying to.

MARNA
Oh, that's unfortunate. Are you waiting for the valet?

BOB
Yes, I think they're all busy right now.

MARNA
I can give you a ride if you'd like. I parked a few blocks down and walked.

BOB
Maybe.

MARNA
Are you happy? We won.

BOB
(smiles)
I'm thrilled. It just feels so weird. I thought I'd be celebrating with more people, but we don't have that big of a team, do we?

MARNA
I don't think size matters, Bob.

BOB
James would start laughing if he heard you say that.

MARNA
I know.

Marty appears on the other side of Bob.

MARTY
You all standing here discussing philosophy?

MARNA
Discussing plans to get home.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

MARTY
You're not partying?

BOB
I didn't plan a party.

MARTY
I know you didn't, but ask anyone else here and I'm sure they have a four-story mansion with room for us to party with them.

BOB
I don't want to disturb anyone.

MARTY
Marna, how about you?

MARNA
I'm alright. A quiet night will be nice after so much chaos.

MARTY
(under his breath)
Bunch of losers...

A WAYS DOWN THE SIDEWALK WE SEE JAMES AND HIS TEAM STANDING BY A LIMO.

Kenny, Susan and Catherine all get in. All drunk, all happy.

Gwen notices Bob, Marna, and Marty standing at the other end of the sidewalk.

GWEN
James.

JAMES
Hm?

Gwen nods in Bob's direction.

JAMES (cont'd)
Oh, looks like he's waiting for his car.

GWEN
It looks like he's not celebrating. He's taking the whole thing home and he's going to go home and throw a party for one.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JAMES
(sighing)
Yeah, that's Bob's style.

GWEN
Well it shouldn't be tonight. We've got room in the limo.

JAMES
You think I should bring them over?

GWEN
Yes! At least try.

JAMES
Alright. Here, get in, I'll see if they're in.

Gwen gets in the limo.

JAMES (cont'd)
(calling to Bob)
Hey!

Bob, Marna, and Marty all look over at James.

James steps away from the limo door and gestures to the inside, like a butler inviting guests inside.

MARTY
You two have a good night, I'm going either way.

Marty walks to Bob - he turns to look back at Bob and Marna.

MARTY (cont'd)
But I hope you come!

Marty bows gracefully to James before entering the limo.

MARTY (cont'd)
(to the people in the limo)
Hello, beautiful people.

Bob looks up at Marna.

MARNA
It feels cruel to refuse.

BOB
I suppose we have to.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

MARNA
It's the polite thing to do.

The two smile at each other and walk to the limo.

Marna nods at James.

MARNA (cont'd)
Excellent work, Mr. Director. Better luck next year.

JAMES
It was well earned.

Marna enters the limo.

It's just Bob and James outside now.

BOB
You sure we're not crashing your party?

JAMES
You never are, Bobby. You only make it better.

James holds out a hand.

JAMES (cont'd)
Congratulations. Best Picture.

Bob shakes his hand and the two hug.

BOB
Thank you, James. I couldn't have done any of it without you.

JAMES
Me neither, buddy. Come on, let's not make them wait any longer.

Bob and James enter the limo.

INT. LIMO - NIGHT

James shuts the door behind him and both creative teams are sitting amongst each other in gorgeous expensive outfits.

James knocks the roof of the limo and they begin driving away.

There's an awkward silence.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

GWEN
Well, let's see it Bob.

Bob holds up his "Best Picture" Award.

Everyone smiles and clamor compliments at Bob and the team.

BOB
Well it's not just me. Let's see the others. Susan, Kenny, Marna, show off what you got!

Susan, Kenny, Marna, and Bob all hold up their awards.

GWEN
Winners! Well done, you guys!

Everyone claps and laughs, the winners gracefully nod and thank the others for their support.

JAMES
Drinks?

EVERYONE
Yes.

James pulls a fresh bottle of champagne out of a container nearby. People pull champagne glasses from a cart on the opposite end of James and pass them around.

James starts working the wrapping off of the champaign cork.

JAMES
I can't believe you did it. All of you. You guys really did it.

BOB
We really did it.

KENNY
We did it.

SUSAN
We fucking did it.

MARNA
We really fucking did it.

Beat.

Everyone realizes what happened.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

(Printed with the demonstration version of Fade In)

EVERYONE
(Insanely celebratory)
YEEEEEEAAAAAAAAAAAAHHHHHHHHHHH!

James pops the cork and starts pouring champagne - half of it making it in the glasses, half of it spilling out.

People slam back their drinks and start screaming and shouting at each other in congratulations and disbelief.

Regardless of team, position, or person - everyone celebrates collectively.

Everybody wins.

BIG BAND MUSIC KICKS IN.

HARD CUT TO:

BLACK SCREEN - TITLE CARD.

"RUM & COKE".

THE END.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY